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IN BRIEF



We will end drug menace in 3 years: Shah in Punjab

CHANDIGARH
Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Wednesday urged voters in Punjab to give the BJP a “chance” to form the next government. He set December 31, 2029 as the deadline to eradicate the drug menace in the State. » **Page 3**

Nandigram bypoll: Cong. candidate released on bail

KOLKATA
Congress candidate for the Nandigram Assembly bypoll Milan Pradhan walked out of a correctional home at Haldia in West Bengal on Wednesday, a day after the Calcutta High Court granted him interim bail till October 20. » **Page 4**

Israel-bound plane drops 16,000 ft in a minute as pilot stabs colleague

Netanyahu hails Indian captain of Dubai-Tel Aviv flight for ‘extraordinary bravery’, says co-pilot tried to crash the plane; flydubai jet makes erratic circle close to Jordan, lands in Saudi Arabia; Defence Minister terms it a ‘terrorist attack attempt’

Associated Press
TEL AVIV

An Indian pilot on a flight from the United Arab Emirates to Israel was stabbed by his co-pilot who was apparently trying to crash the aircraft on Wednesday, Israel’s Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said. Passengers and crew subdued the attacker, and the plane made a safe emergency landing in Saudi Arabia. Captain Smit Machchhar sustained serious injuries. The flydubai flight FZ 1073 was travelling from Dubai to Tel Aviv carrying 174 people, dozens of them Israelis. Around two-and-a-half hours after leaving Dubai, the Boeing 737 MAX aircraft issued an emergency alert and descended



Passengers who were on the flydubai flight arrive at the Ben Gurion International Airport in Tel Aviv, Israel, on Wednesday night. AP

from 33,000 feet to 17,000 feet in about a minute, before making an erratic circle close to the Jordanian border and landing in Tabuk in Saudi Arabia about an hour later, according to Flightradar24. The episode prompted Israel to scramble warplanes amid concerns of possible hijacking. Video footage circulating online shows two men on the floor of the plane, bloodied and wounded. Two people appear to be providing medical treatment, while two others guard the cockpit. “We are guarding the pilot,” one person says in Hebrew.

In another video, passengers weep and cry out in distress as the aircraft shakes. The passengers and crew who intervened “saved many lives and prevented a major disaster,” Mr. Netanyahu said, adding that the co-pilot, whose identity was not immediately shared by authorities, has been arrested in Saudi Arabia and is being questioned by authorities. Saudi Arabia had no immediate comment. Mr. Netanyahu praised Captain Machchhar for his “extraordinary bravery.” “Despite being stabbed and seriously injured, he fought back... preventing a catastrophic mid-air disaster. He saved the lives of 174 people, including Israeli citizens and other nationals,” Mr. Netanyahu wrote on X. Captain Machchhar has been admitted to a hospital in Tabuk city and is reported to be in stable condition. Later in the day, the passengers were taken to Israel in a separate aircraft. Israel has decided to ramp up security checks on pilots flying into the country following the incident, a spokesperson for the Prime Minister’s Office said. Israeli Defence Minister Israel Katz said the incident aboard the plane “was a jihadist terrorist attack attempt, which was thwarted only thanks to the bravery of several Israeli passengers who broke into the cockpit and overpowered the terrorist”. **CONTINUED ON » PAGE 10**

‘CONDITIONAL RELAXATION’
SC rules out total ban on fireworks for Deepavali
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INDIA-EFTA DEAL
One plus one equals three
Partnership can deliver across sectors, writes Ambassador of Iceland
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MAMMOTH CHASE
Gill and Rohit shine as India seals series
SPORT » PAGE 17

Golden duo



Reaping it rich: Compound archers Chikitha Taniparthi and Sahil Jadhav beat South Korea in a shoot-off to retain the mixed team title at the Asian Games on Wednesday. India won two more gold in the sport and one in shooting to boost its medal tally. R.V. MOORTHY (REPORT: PAGE 15)

INDIA bloc to kick off campaign against CEC, SIR across country from tomorrow

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

The Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) on Wednesday announced a nationwide campaign beginning Friday against the Election Commission (EC) and the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. The graded agitation plan includes protest marches at district headquarters, a march to the Election Commission, and a joint appeal to the Chief Justice of India for expedited hearings in cases related to the SIR and alleged electoral “malpractices”. The decisions were taken after a three-and-a-half-hour meeting attended by 33 leaders from 19



United voice: Leaders of INDIA bloc parties addressing the media after a meeting in New Delhi on Wednesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

political parties. Independent MP and senior Supreme Court lawyer Kapil Sibal also participated. Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said the leaders had agreed to fight together. “With unanimity, everyone vowed to fight to-

gether,” he said at a press conference. While there was no direct reference to involving the Cockroach Janta Party, leaders agreed that the bloc should engage with civil society and secular parties outside the alliance.

Poll body extends SIR dates for A.P., Meghalaya

NEW DELHI
A full bench of the Election Commission convened on Wednesday, in what was the second such meeting in four days, and decided to extend the dates for publication of the final electoral rolls under the SIR in Andhra Pradesh and Meghalaya. » **PAGE 11**

Notable absentees at the meeting included the DMK, which has refused to share a stage with the Congress after the Tamil Nadu election.

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HC rejects Umar Khalid, Sharjeel Imam bail pleas

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

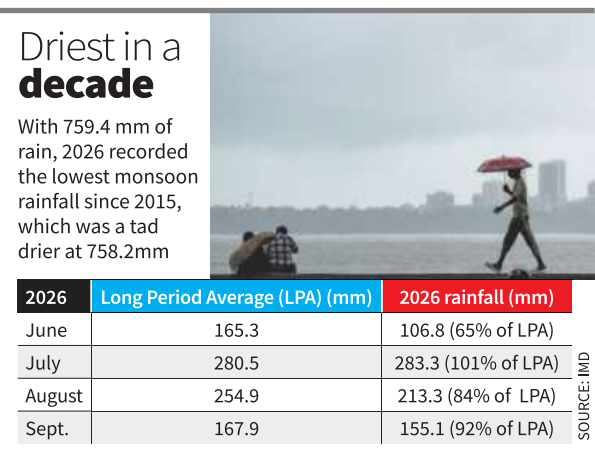
The Delhi High Court on Wednesday rejected the bail pleas of activists Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam in a case registered under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act in connection with the “larger conspiracy” behind the 2020 riots in north-east Delhi. A Bench of Justices Prathiba M. Singh and Dinesh Bhattacharya dismissed the duo’s third bail applications in the case. **‘Can’t alter SC order’** The High Court said it could not alter the Supreme Court’s January 5 order, which permitted Mr. Khalid and Mr. Imam to seek bail upon completion

of the examination of protected witnesses or on expiry of one year from the date of the order, whichever is earlier. Delhi Police’s Special Cell, which is handling the probe, has also named activist Khalid Saifi and former AAP councillor Tahir Husain as accused in the ‘larger conspiracy’ case. The latest pleas were filed after a trial court rejected the accused’s bail applications for the third time on July 4. Mr. Imam and Mr. Khalid were arrested on August 25 and September 13, 2020 respectively. Opposing the pleas, Delhi Police alleged that the duo was among the “masterminds” of the conspiracy behind the riots, which claimed 53 lives.

Southwest monsoon ends with 12% deficit, October rain also likely below normal: IMD

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

India’s 2026 southwest monsoon ended with 759.4 mm of rain, 12.6% below the 868.6-mm normal, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said on Wednesday. At 87% of the Long Period Average (LPA), this is the lowest rainfall recorded during the monsoon since 2015, which was a tad drier at 758.2 mm. The east and northeast region, which recorded 1,017.1 mm of rainfall, had its driest monsoon since 1901, or since the IMD started to keep systematic records. The subdued rainfall was in line with forecasts by global weather agen-



cies, including the IMD, which anticipated one of the strongest El Ninos in recent history. The IMD had, since April, predicted a subdued monsoon rainfall and overall, reality corresponded to what was fore-

cast. On April 13, for instance, it anticipated the June-September rain to be at 92% of LPA, with an error window of 5%. The May 29 update lowered that to 90% with a 4% error window. The IMD’s final esti-

mate sits within this range. The southwest monsoon this year is in the process of withdrawal and is likely to completely exit within the first weeks of October, IMD Director-General M. Mohapatra said. The country will then see the advent of the north-east monsoon. With the El Nino still gaining strength, rainfall for the country in October is likely to be below 85% of the LPA of about 75.4 mm. Most regions are expected to get below-normal rain, except parts of northwest India, southern peninsular India, and isolated pockets of the east. **CONTINUED ON » PAGE 10**

LeT ‘commander’ killed in J&K: Army

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

A Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) ‘commander’ active in the Pir Panjal Valley and south Kashmir was killed in an ongoing operation in Budgam district of Jammu and Kashmir, the Army said on Wednesday. The body of the terrorist, identified as Mohammad Asif alias Hashim Moosa, was recovered along with “war-like stores” during a search in Palmaidan, the Army said, adding that the combing operation continued in the area. Officials said the killing of Moosa is a breakthrough for the security forces, as he had remained active in



Security forces keeping watch in Budgam district of Jammu and Kashmir on Wednesday. ANI

central and south Kashmir for several years. They said Moosa coordinated many attacks in the region and was part of the larger LeT group active in the Kashmir Valley.

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‘FOUR KILLED SINCE 2022’ » PAGE 10

We will end drug menace in 3 years, Shah tells Punjab voters

BJP will go to the polls with this sole agenda, says Union Minister while describing the Bhagwant Mann-led AAP govt. as ‘incompetent’; cites examples to assert that BJP delivers on its promises

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Wednesday urged voters in Punjab to give the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) a “chance” to form the next government and make the State drug-free. He set December 31, 2029, as the deadline to eradicate the drug menace in the State.

Mr. Shah said the Punjab elections will be fought on issues concerning farmers, industry, law and order, and women's safety, but the BJP will go to the polls with a sole agenda - the fight against drugs.

“I promise the mothers and youth of Punjab that if you support the BJP in this election, vote for the lotus and by December 31, 2029, we will free Punjab from the trade of *chitta* (synthetic drugs),” he said in Punjab's Jalandhar, addressing



Union Home Minister Amit Shah during the conclusion of the ‘Drug-Free Punjab Yatra’, in Jalandhar on Wednesday. ANI

a gathering as part of the party's ‘Nasha Mukht Punjab Yatra’ campaign.

Pointing out that the BJP can fulfil its promises, Mr. Shah said, “What we have said, we have delivered. Under the leadership of *Modi ji*, the BJP accomplished the task of freeing Jammu and Kashmir from terrorism. The BJP achieved the task of ending

the 50-year-old Naxalite problem by setting a timeline. And the BJP also accomplished the task of ending terrorism in the Northeast. And now it is the turn of a drug-free Punjab.”

Hitting out at the Aam Aadmi Party government, Mr. Shah described the party as “incompetent”, saying it cannot end the

drug menace. “They (AAP) feel no shame. Those who are intoxicated and disrespect the Gurus cannot free Punjab from drugs,” he said.

Mr. Shah hit out at Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann and said his government has not acted against the drug mafia. “I want to ask the Chief Minister of Punjab, more than 5,000 people across the country went to jail under NDPS. Where drugs are sold the most, in Punjab, not a single action has been taken this year,” he said.

“We also formed the Narco Coordination Centre (NCORD), where the Chief Minister was made the chairman. Bhagwant Mann *sahab*, tell me how many meetings of NCORD you held,” he asked. Mr. Shah said that for three years, he has been organising NCORD meetings in every State, but Punjab has not held a single meeting.

Gandak river breaches three embankments, causes floods in low-lying areas across Bihar

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

After heavy rain in the catchment areas in Nepal, the Gandak river, known as Narayani in Nepal, breached at least three embankments over the past two days in West Champaran district of Bihar along the India-Nepal border, creating panic among residents.

The breaches, from Monday night to Tuesday morning, inundated low-lying areas and agricultural fields in the district, besides parts of Bagaha town. The Gandak, Kosi, Bagmati and Sone rivers are swollen and surging in Bihar's border districts, including West Champaran, East Champaran, Gopalganj, Saran, Muzaffarpur, Vaishali, Supaul, Khagaria and Saharsa.

Three breaches

According to an official, following heavy discharge of water from the Valmiki-



An elderly man carrying children on a boat on Wednesday. ANI

nagar barrage in West Champaran district, the first breach occurred at Kharatwa Daroga Chowk under Singhari Pipariya panchayat of Bagaha on the night of Monday. The second breach occurred near Phulia Khad village in Bairia block, while the third embankment was breached on the morning of Tuesday near Makari Tesarahiya village.

A ring *bandha* (embankment) near Pandey Tola in Shreya panchayat of Areraj block in East Champaran district was also breached

in the early hours of Wednesday, an official said.

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary has been conducting regular aerial surveys of the affected areas. On Wednesday, he surveyed West Champaran and directed officials to expedite relief and rescue measures.

In West Champaran, affected families have taken shelter on elevated embankment sections, while the district administration has begun round-the-clock patrolling to prevent breaches.

Disaster Management Department Principal Secretary Santosh Kumar Mall said one company each of the National Disaster Response Force and State Disaster Response Force had been dispatched to the affected areas.

Relief camps, have been set up, while 23 community kitchens are operating across West Champaran, District Magistrate Taran-jot Singh said.

Barapullah Phase-3 flyover debut leaves commuters in 3.5-km jam

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

A day after Union Home Minister Amit Shah inaugurated the Barapullah Phase-3 elevated corridor aimed at cutting travel time between Mayur Vihar and south Delhi to about 15 minutes, the new stretch was hit by a major traffic jam on Wednesday morning, with queues stretching up to 3.5 kilometres and commuters reporting waits of 40-60 minutes. A traffic police officer said thousands of vehicles converged on the route, over-



A traffic jam on the Barapullah elevated road on Wednesday. @PALLAVABAGLA-X

whelming the road network at its exit.

“I normally take NH-24 while going to court, but when I saw new route on Google Maps. I turned towards it, but the turn end-

ed up costing me about 20-25 minutes. The entry to Barapullah Phase-3 was barricaded and there was a huge traffic jam at Mayur Vihar,” said Alabhya Dharmija, an Advocate-on-Record in the Supreme Court, who lives in Noida.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, South Delhi Deputy Commissioner of Police (Traffic) Sandeep Gupta said Google Maps had directed commuters towards the new corridor without reflecting the developing congestion, resulting in a sudden concentration of traffic.

CM positions TVK as an ‘organic successor’ to AIADMK

R. Krishnamoorthy
DHARAPURAM

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Wednesday made no bones about his keenness to position his party as an organic successor of the AIADMK, as he extolled the

leadership acumen of late Chief Ministers Jayalalithaa and M.G. Ramachandran in handling arch-rival DMK umpteen times.

“The present AIADMK leadership's brazen attempt at negating the legacies of the iconic leaders by contemplating a tie-up

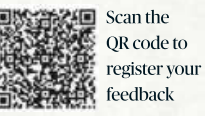
even with its arch-rival for government formation was what spurred TVK candidate Sathyabama into exiting the Dravidian party she had served for decades,” he claimed.

Speaking at a byelection campaign meeting in Dharpuram (Reserved) consti-

tuency, where Ms. Sathyabama has been fielded, he sought to counter the charge of the Opposition parties that she had been bought. In May, she was elected from the constituency on an AIADMK ticket. Thereafter, she resigned and joined the TVK.

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**HIMACHAL PRADESH
PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT**

**E-Procurement Notice
NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)**

No.PW-SE-VIII/WA-2/Tender-PMGSY-V/2026-27- 6184-6221 Dated-29-09-2026

On the behalf of the Governor of Himachal Pradesh, Superintending Engineer, 8th Circle, HPPWD Hamirpur is hereby invited percentage-rate bids through electronic tendering system for the construction of road sanctioned under Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana-IV Batch-I for the following package of work including their maintenance for a period of five (05) years, from eligible and approved contractors.

Sr. No.	District/ Circle	Division	Package No	Name of Road	Length (In km.)	Estimated Cost Excl. GST (Rs. in Lacs)	5-Year Maint. Cost
1.	Hamirpur	Tauni Devi	HP-03-185	C/o Link road from Gahara to Luharda via Dukhral from km. 0/0 to 3/750	3.750	476.58	20.48

Total Cost Excl. GST (Rs. in Lacs) : 497.06
Period of completion on Const. Part (In Months) : 15 Months
Bid Security (Rs. in Lacs) : 9.94
Tender Fee (Non Refundable) (In Rs.), : 7000

Note:-The rates to be quoted by the bidder shall be inclusive of all taxes, royalties, duties and other levies that the contractor will have to pay for the performance of this contract but excluding GST. GST at prevalent rates will be added/paid to the value offered by the bidder separately.
Maintenance Period is five (05) years after date of completion of construction work.
Availability of Bid Document and mode of submission:- The bid document is available online and bid should be submitted online on website <https://pmgsytendershp.gov.in>. The bidders are advised to note the other details of the tender from the website <https://pmgsytendershp.gov.in>.

1. Key Dates:-

Sr. No.	Particulars	Date & Time	Hrs.
(i)	Date of online Publication	05.10.2026 at 10:00	Hrs.
(ii)	Document Download Start Date	05.10.2026 at 10:00	Hrs.
(iii)	Document Download End Date	27.10.2026 at 10:00	Hrs.
(iv)	Bid Submission Start Date	05.10.2026 at 10:00	Hrs.
(v)	Bid Submission End Date	27.10.2026 at 10:00	Hrs.
(vi)	Opening of Technical Bids	27.10.2026 at 11:30	Hrs.

2. Other details can be seen in the bidding document. Even though the system will attempt to notify the bidders of any bid updates, the Employer shall not be liable for any information not received by the bidder. It is the bidder's responsibility to verify the website for the latest information related to the tender(s).

3. The Employer reserves the right to extend or cancel the bids without assigning any reasons thereof.

Sd/-
Superintending Engineer,
8th Circle HPPWD.,
Hamirpur
E-mail ID:- hp-ham@nic.in
Phone No. 01972-223965

HP / 3811/26-27 HIM SUCHANA AVAM JAN SAMPARK

PUBLIC NOTICE

APPLICATION FOR REGISTRATION OF THE COMMERCIAL COMPONENT OF MIXED LAND USE COLONY NAMEDLY "SMARTWORLD SKY ARC AVENUE" LOCATED AT SECTOR 69, GURUGRAM BEING DEVELOPED BY M/s RIVERDAY INFRASTRUCTURE PVT. LTD.

It is for the information of the general public that an application dated 22.09.2026 for registration of the project under Section 4 of the Act of 2016 is submitted in the Authority for the project "Smartworld Sky Arc Avenue".

The Department of Town & Country Planning, Haryana granted license no. 90 of 2024 dated 18.07.2024 to M/s Modgen Developers Pvt. Ltd. for setting up of Mixed Land Use Colony under TOD Policy over an area measuring 11,68875 acres (an area measuring 11.68875 acres. Subsequently, Phase 1 has been registered for the project namely "Smartworld Sky Arc" vide RC No. 105 of 2024 dated 11.10.2024 and Phase 5 has been registered for the project namely "Trump Residences Gurgaon" vide RC No. 28 of 2025 dated 13.03.2025.

Further, the Directorate of Town & Country Planning, Haryana has granted the Change of Developer (COD) Permission in favour of M/s Riverday Infrastructure Private Limited vide Memo No. LC-5319(JERK)/2024/28240 dated 09.09.2024 for an area measuring 11.68875 acres. Subsequently, Phase 1 has been registered for the project namely "Smartworld Sky Arc" vide RC No. 105 of 2024 dated 11.10.2024 and Phase 5 has been registered for the project namely "Trump Residences Gurgaon" vide RC No. 28 of 2025 dated 13.03.2025.

Afterwards, the Directorate of Town & Country Planning, Haryana has granted the revised phasing plan vide Drawing No. DTCP 10796 dated 23.01.2025 and revised demarcation cum zoning plan vide Drawing No. DTCP 10797 dated 23.01.2025.

Now, the Directorate of Town & Country Planning, Haryana has approved the revised building plans for Phase 3, 4, & 5A part of Mixed Land Use Colony under TOD Policy at Sector 69, Gurugram, vide Memo no. ZP-2017/PA(DK)/2026/33764 dated 21.09.2026, valid upto 20.09.2031.

The promoter has now approached the Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurugram, for the registration of the Phase 5A under Section 4 of the Act, 2016 whereas Phase 1 has been registered for the project namely "Smartworld Sky Arc" vide RC No. 105 of 2024 dated 11.10.2024 and Phase 5 has been registered for the project namely "Trump Residences Gurgaon" vide RC No. 28 of 2025 dated 13.03.2025.

Meanwhile, the promoter has submitted an affidavit from the Director of the promoter company stating that the developer has not obtained any RERA registration, nor advertised, marketed, booked, sold or offered to sale, or invited persons to purchase in any manner any plo/ apartment/ dwelling unit, etc. with respect to Phase 3, 4, & 5A of the license no. 90 of 2024 dated 18.07.2024.

Further, the promoter has submitted an affidavit dated 11.10.2024 from the Director of the promoter company at the time of registration of "Smartworld Sky Arc" stating that no advertisement, marketing, booking and sale etc. has been done nor any third party rights created w.r.t. the 11.5 acres land migrated from the said IT Park license no. 28 of 2009 by the erstwhile promoter i.e. Red Parks Pvt. Ltd. or by the company from the date of grant of licence no. 29 of 2009 for IT Park upto grant of RERA Registration of the project.

The relevant application and related documents are available in the office of the Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurugram which can be seen by any concerned on any working day during office hours i.e., 9.00 a.m. to 4.00 p.m. up to 15.10.2026. Also, if anyone wishes to appear, may appear before the Authority on 19.10.2026 at 11:00 am during the hearing.

Given under the approval of the Authority and its seal.

Dated: 01.10.2026

Secretary,
Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurugram

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NOTIFICATION

The KSCSTE is seeking qualified candidates for the post of Director, KSCSTE-JNTBGRI

For details log on to www.kscste.kerala.gov.in.

Last date for the receipt of application is **22.10.2026, 5.00 p.m**

D3/571/2026 EXECUTIVE VICE PRESIDENT

उत्तराखण्ड पावर कारपोरेशन लिमिटेड
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18 ई.सी. रोड, देहरादून दूरभाष : 2652916 Emailedndn@yahoo.com

पत्रांक: 4394/ विनिख (उ)/ दिनांक 30/09/26

निविदा सूचना

अधोहस्ताक्षरकर्ता द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु उत्तराखण्ड शासन द्वारा प्रदत्त विद्युत कार्यो के लिए 'क' श्रेणी के लाईसेन्स धारक, वैध जी.एस.टी. ई.पी.एफ., ई.एस.आई.सी. के अन्तर्गत पंजीकृत, आयकर/पैन कार्ड धारक निविदादाताओं से मुहरबन्द निविदाये दो भागो मे (प्रथम भाग में निविदा धरोहर धनराशि संबंधी घोषणा पत्र, नियम एवं शर्तें, उत्तराखण्ड विद्युत निरीक्षक द्वारा निर्मित 'ए' क्लास लाईसेंस की प्रतिलिपि, जी.एस.टी पंजीकरण, पेनकार्ड आदि एवं द्वितीय भाग में दर्जे जो कि निविदा खुलने की तिथि से कम से कम छः माह तक वैध हो) दिनांक 16.10.2026 को 14.00 बजे तक आमंत्रित की जाती है जिसका प्रथम भाग उसी दिन 15.00 बजे उपस्थित निविदादाताओं अथवा उनके प्रतिनिधियों के सम्मुख अधोहस्ताक्षरों द्वारा सार्वजनिक रूप से खोला जायेगा। प्रथम भाग के मूल्यांकन के बाद द्वितीय भाग खोला जायेगा। निविदा प्रपत्र किसी भी कार्य दिवस में वैध जी.एस.टी. धारक के द्वारा दिनांक 15.10.2026 (14:00 बजे) तक अधोहस्ताक्षरी के कार्यालय से निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य नगद (अप्रतिदेय) जमा कर क्रय किये जा सकते हैं। बिना निविदा धरोहर धनराशि व अन्य संबंधित घोषणा पत्र के निविदा भाग-2 नहीं खोली जायेगी। निविदा खुलने की तिथि में अवकाश होने / अधोहस्ताक्षरी के मुख्यालय से बाहर होने पर अगले कार्य दिवस को निविदा खोली जाएगी। अधोहस्ताक्षरी को यह अधिकार होगा कि वह बिना कारण बताये समस्त अथवा किसी भी निविदा को निरस्त कर सकते हैं। विस्तृत नियम एवं शर्तें निविदा प्रपत्र में वर्णित हैं।

निविदा संख्या 28/EDD(N)/2026-2027, Work - Replacement of Damaged AB Cable under EDDS Anarwala EDD(North) की धरोहर राशि ₹ 20,00,000.00, निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य ₹ 250.00 G.S.T.Extra.

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NOTIFICATION

Candidates who applied for the contractual post of **a) Academic Coordinator** and **b) Associate Professor in Screen Acting** (for 11-month tenure) at the Tripura Film & Television Institute (TFTI), under the Information & Cultural Affairs Department, Government of Tripura, pursuant to Advertisement No. F.75 (69)-ICA/TFTI/2025 dated June 30, 2026, are hereby notified that the Interview/ Personality Test is scheduled for 8th October, 2026, starting at 12:00 PM onwards.

For more detailed information and schedule of the Interview/ Personality Test programme please visit Institute's website: www.tfti.ac.in

Registrar
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ICA/D/1069/26

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E PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE
NIT No.38/MAU61-USIOBH/OTH/206/2026-CEAG-part (1) Dt. 30.09.2026
Name of Work: APCRDA-Housing & Buildings -District Cooling Plant RFP for 'Development of District Cooling System for Business Entities along Seed Access Road in Amaravati, Andhra Pradesh under Public Private Partnership (PPP) Basis'. The bid can be downloaded on AP e-procurement portal from 06.10.2026 to 20.11.2026 up to 14.00 Hrs. Due date for submission of Bid 20.11.2026 up to 15.00 Hrs, Technical bid opening 20.11.2026 @16.00Hrs. For further details please refer to www.approcurement.gov.in and <https://crda.ap.gov.in>

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Letter No: 893 Date: 30/09/2026

Date Extension Notice-06

Due to unavoidable circumstances, due dates in respect of online Bid Identification No. T-01/EE(Solar)/2026-27 are revised as follows:
Last Date /Time of Receipt of bid on the portal:14-10-2026upto 16:00 Hrs.
Last Date /Time of submissionof bid in Office :16-10-2026 upto 12:00 Hrs.

Date of opening of the bid on website :16-10-2026from 13:00 Hrs.

All other details and terms & conditions shall remain same. Detail of subsequent addendum/corrigendum/cancellation etc. may be obtained from the website.

Further details can be seen from the e-procurement portal <http://uktenders.gov.in>.

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NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Notice Inviting Expression of Interest (EOI)

Tender No.	Material Description	Due Date
SI.No.1	Rebuild of Chemical Bagasse plant with upgraded technology for optimizing the reject handling system to reduce utility and power consumption by running 600TPD of unbleached chemical bagasse pulp production in Single Street and reducing weak black liquor generation.	26.10.2026

TNPL Invites Tender for the Following:

Tender No.	Material Description	Due Date
262713 004173	Procurement of Alkaline Sizing Chemicals with Alky	14.10.2026

Corrigendum if any will be issued in TNPL Website and NIC portal only. For further details, please visit websites: www.tnpl.com / <https://tntenders.gov.in/nicgep/app> DIPP / 2983 / Tender / 2026

TNPL-MAKER OF BAGASSE BASED ECO-FRIENDLY PAPER

INBRIEF



Meerut ‘Blue Drum’ murder: court convicts wife, partner

The Meerut district court on Wednesday held Muskan Rastogi and her partner Sahil Shukla guilty of the murder of merchant navy officer Saurabh Rajput, Muskan’s husband, in the March 2025 “Blue Drum” murder case, bringing the trial to an end after 13 months and 126 hearings. The court held the two guilty of murder as well as attempting to conceal Rajput’s body. The court will announce its order on punishment after 15 days. District Judge Arvind Mishra said, “There is no place in a civilised society for such crimes.” The court will hear the convicts on the question of sentence before passing its final order. PTI

Goa nightclub fire: owners offer ₹15 lakh ex gratia to kin

The Bombay High Court on Wednesday asked the families of the 25 people, who were killed in a devastating fire at a Goa nightclub in December, to respond to an offer by its owners to pay ₹15 lakh each as *ex gratia*. A Division Bench of the High Court in Goa recorded the statement made on behalf of Saurav and Gaurav Luthra, brothers and owners of the fire-hit nightclub Birch by Romeo Lane, that they were willing to pay the amount to each of the 25 victims’ families. The court adjourned the matter to October 12 to enable the affected families to state their position on the proposed compensation. PTI

Molestation case: toeing line is one thing but bending over is another, says SC to U.P. Police

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

“Toeing the line is one thing but bending over is another,” the Supreme Court on Wednesday said while castigating Uttar Pradesh police for registering a molestation case against an “unknown person” despite having arrested the accused on the spot.

Making sharp observations while hearing a plea for the cancellation of anticipatory bail of an accused in a molestation case in Bulandshahr district, the Supreme Court said the Uttar Pradesh police may be disbanded and all investigations handed over to the CBI.

A Bench of Justices Sanjay Kumar and Sanjeev Sachdeva said, “Toeing the line is one thing but bending over is another. And this kind of cover-up job?



It is better if we ask the CBI to step in and take over all U.P. police investigations: SC

Less said the better.” Directing the Station House Officer (SHO) to be present in the courtroom on the next date of hearing, the Bench said, “This is how you do the investigation. We have seen lacunae in many cases. In everything, you have an agenda. How will people trust you if this is how you proceed with these matters?”

“It is better if we ask the CBI to step in and take over all U.P. police investigations. We might as well disband the U.P. police. This nonsense has to stop at some point,” the Bench said.

‘No investigation done’ It took note of the petitioner’s in-person submissions that the police report was “biased”. She said the police had initially registered an FIR against an “unknown person” and when the court asked for the report, they just added the name of the accused in it, without carrying out any investigation. The petitioner claimed that the police registered an FIR against an “unknown” motorcycle rider, despite having caught the suspect on the spot and handed him over to the local police.

Inquiry committee into Gulmarg gondola accident for extra rescue wheel and guides as first responders

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

The inquiry committee into the Gulmarg gondola mishap, which left 300 tourists stuck mid-air in cabins for six hours on May 25 this year, has called for an extra layer of rescue options and recommended training in vertical rescue operations for guides and photographers “to become the first responders”. Meanwhile, a team from the French company (Poma), which installed the cable car, will brief the committee too. Officials said the preliminary inquiry report into the mishap has identified a few gaps in the rescue in north Kashmir’s Baramulla district. Gulmarg gondola is Asia’s highest cable car. It suggested an additional

rescue bull wheel independent of the current section of the bull wheel and gearbox, which runs the cable over towering pylon through pine-dotted forests and rugged mountains. “The second layer of rescue bull wheel will become active when the system fails and will allow rescue operations independently and smoothly,” said the officials, privy to the inquiry report. It also recommended training in vertical rescue operations, which are rope-based rescues, for registered ski guides, tourist guides, photographers and pony owners. “The idea is that these service providers should become the first responders in case of any emergency,” said the officials. Around 100 locals are re-



Rescue operation on after 300 tourists were stranded aboard the Gulmarg gondola on May 25 this year. FILE PHOTO

gistered with the tourism department to provide these services to tourists. Meanwhile, the gearbox that developed a snag on May 25 was shifted to Delhi and was being handled by

The Samajwadi Party (SP) has announced senior leader Ram Gopal Yadav and industrialist Dhanraj Nathwani as its candidates for the upcoming Rajya Sabha election in Uttar Pradesh. While Mr. Ram Gopal, SP’s key strategist and uncle of party president Akhilesh Yadav, was widely expected to make the cut, the choice of Mr. Dhanraj, group president at Reliance Industries Limited, who is seen as one of the most trusted confidants of the Ambani family, has created a buzz in political and corporate circles. The choice is seen as a pragmatic move ahead of the Assembly election next year, for instead of pushing the PDA (*Pichhda*, Dalit, *Alpsankhyak*) card, the party has taken the resource-and-relationship path to challenge the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and



Ram Gopal Yadav (fourth from right) and Dhanraj Nathwani (second from right) filed their papers in Lucknow on Wednesday. ANI

signal to its key ally, the Congress. Mr. Yadav accompanied Mr. Dhanraj and Mr. Ram Gopal to file their nomination papers in Lucknow, skipping the INDIA bloc meet in Delhi. Mr. Dhanraj, who is also a director on the board of Reliance New Energy Limited and president of the Gujarat Cricket Association, is the son of Parimal Nathwani, a senior Reliance corporate affairs director and a veteran politi-

cian who was re-elected in June to his fourth consecutive term in the Upper House from Jharkhand as a National Democratic Alliance (NDA)-backed Independent. For two terms, the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha and the YSR Congress Party backed him. Influential voices From Amar Singh and Anil Ambani in the Mulayam Singh Yadav era to Sanjay Seth and Surendra Nagar,

Cong. candidate released on bail, steps up campaign for Nandigram byelection

Confident of victory; people want son of the soil, not outsider to win, says Milan Pradhan; police put pressure to withdraw from electoral contest after they picked him up on Sept. 18, he alleges

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Congress candidate for the Nandigram Assembly byelection Milan Pradhan walked out of a correctional home at Haldia in West Bengal’s Purba Medinipur district on Wednesday, a day after the Calcutta High Court granted him interim bail till October 20. Mr. Pradhan, who was arrested on September 18 in connection with an FIR registered 19 years ago during the Nandigram land agitation, was received by a large number of party workers. “There is not much time left. The people of Nandigram want the son of the soil, not someone from outside, to win. I am confident of securing victory,” he told mediapersons. Byelections to the Nandigram and Rejinagar Assembly seats are scheduled for October 6. Campaigning ends on October 4 while counting of votes will take place on October 9. Mr. Pradhan was arrest-



Congress candidate Milan Pradhan speaking to mediapersons after he was released from a correctional home in Haldia on Wednesday. PTI

ed hours after the nominee of Mamata Banerjee’s Trinamool Congress faction backed out of the contest and it pledged support for the Congress candidate. Following his release, Mr. Pradhan alleged that the police pressured him to withdraw his candidacy after they picked him up. When he refused, he was blindfolded, taken to Chandipur, and later arrested, he claimed. In his absence, Mr. Pradhan’s wife and local Congress leaders were cam-

paigning in Nandigram. The Assembly seat was vacated by Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, who chose to retain Bhabanipur, which he had also won in the Assembly election earlier this year. The BJP has fielded Hsiran Rath, mother of Mr. Adhikari’s aide Chandranath Rath, who was killed on May 6. The contest is a prestige fight for Mr. Adhikari, who represented the seat from 2021 to 2026, when he was Leader of the Opposition. The State go-

vernment has filed an appeal in the Supreme Court against the interim bail granted to Mr. Pradhan. Meanwhile, two Congress leaders, Manick Fakir and Sukriti Ranjan Biswas, who were campaigning in Nandigram, were detained during the day. The party claimed that the police did not specify the reason for the action.

ISF’s plea dismissed The High Court on Wednesday dismissed a plea filed by the Indian Secular Front (ISF) challenging the Election Commission’s (EC) decision to reassign the ‘envelope’ poll symbol, with which it had contested the 2024 Lok Sabha and 2026 Assembly elections. The EC on September 18 allotted new names and symbols to the two factions of the Trinamool Congress. The Ritabrata Banerjee-led faction was allotted the name ‘Democratic Trinamool Congress’ with the ‘envelope’ symbol. The EC then allotted the ISF the ‘almirah’ symbol.

HC stays Waze’s bail in 2021 Antilia bomb scare case

Chinmay Gaikwad
MUMBAI

The Bombay High Court on Wednesday stayed the bail granted by a special court to dismissed policeman Sachin Waze in the 2021 Antilia bomb scare case.

A Bench of Justices Girish Kulkarni and Neela Gokhale posted for October 7 the appeal filed by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) challenging the special court order and issued notice to Mr. Waze. “We are granting an adjournment stay on the September 29 order passed by the special court. The State authorities shall immediately convey our order to the jail authorities concerned,” the court said. On February 25, 2021, an SUV with explosives inside was found near industrialist Mukesh Ambani’s residence ‘Antilia’ in south Mumbai. Businessman Mansukh Hiran, who was in possession of the SUV before it was allegedly stolen, was found dead in a creek in neighbouring Thane on March 5, 2021. Mr. Waze was arrested by the NIA on March 13, 2021 in the combined case of the Antilia bomb scare and Hiran’s killing.

Case was purposely linked to terrorism to serve political purpose, discredit the then MVA govt., the Congress alleged

Meanwhile, the Maharashtra Congress unit on Wednesday alleged that the Antilia bomb scare case was purposely linked to terrorism to serve a political purpose and discredit the then Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) government. “The conspiracy was aimed at not only discrediting the then MVA government but also preventing certain accused from coming to light,” Congress leader Sachin Sawant said at a press conference.

‘Agencies misused’ Mr. Sawant also alleged that the NIA took over the case from the Maharashtra Anti-Terrorism Squad when the latter was about to arrest the accused. He claimed that the NIA had failed to get to the root of the case and “efforts were being made to protect some people”. “Central investigating agencies are being misused for political purposes,” he alleged.

Akhilesh fields uncle, picks Reliance executive in surprise, strategic move for Rajya Sabha election

Anuj Kumar
NEW DELHI

The Samajwadi Party (SP) has announced senior leader Ram Gopal Yadav and industrialist Dhanraj Nathwani as its candidates for the upcoming Rajya Sabha election in Uttar Pradesh. While Mr. Ram Gopal, SP’s key strategist and uncle of party president Akhilesh Yadav, was widely expected to make the cut, the choice of Mr. Dhanraj, group president at Reliance Industries Limited, who is seen as one of the most trusted confidants of the Ambani family, has created a buzz in political and corporate circles. The choice is seen as a pragmatic move ahead of the Assembly election next year, for instead of pushing the PDA (*Pichhda*, Dalit, *Alpsankhyak*) card, the party has taken the resource-and-relationship path to challenge the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and



Ram Gopal Yadav (fourth from right) and Dhanraj Nathwani (second from right) filed their papers in Lucknow on Wednesday. ANI

signal to its key ally, the Congress. Mr. Yadav accompanied Mr. Dhanraj and Mr. Ram Gopal to file their nomination papers in Lucknow, skipping the INDIA bloc meet in Delhi. Mr. Dhanraj, who is also a director on the board of Reliance New Energy Limited and president of the Gujarat Cricket Association, is the son of Parimal Nathwani, a senior Reliance corporate affairs director and a veteran politi-

cian who was re-elected in June to his fourth consecutive term in the Upper House from Jharkhand as a National Democratic Alliance (NDA)-backed Independent. For two terms, the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha and the YSR Congress Party backed him. Influential voices From Amar Singh and Anil Ambani in the Mulayam Singh Yadav era to Sanjay Seth and Surendra Nagar,

party sources say the SP has been sending influential corporate voices with cross-party networks to the Rajya Sabha. “Akhileshji has a track record of bringing investment in the State, and after the Lok Sabha poll, the corporate world sees him as the only credible face for development in U.P.,” senior party leader Udaiveer Singh told *The Hindu*, adding the SP stands as much for development and prosperity as for equality and social justice. Meanwhile, BJP ally Om Prakash Rajbhar mocked the selection, questioning how fielding an affluent, elite corporate executive aligns with SP’s highly publicised PDA formula. He wrote on X that Mr. Ram Gopal’s nomination “makes it P for *parivar* (family)” and with Mr. Dhanraj, “D stands for *daulat-mand* (affluent)”. With the Nathwani family’s close ties to the BJP lea-

dership, observers say it would be difficult to criticise the candidate’s credentials, forcing the ruling alliance to frame it as SP’s ideological hypocrisy. 10 seats up for grabs Ten Rajya Sabha seats are up for grabs in U.P. in the election scheduled for October 16. Based on the current alignment and strength of the Legislative Assembly, calculations indicate that the BJP-led NDA is poised to secure seven seats. At the same time, the SP is positioned to claim two. A tight contest is expected for the 10th seat, as the BJP is expected to have a surplus of 31 or 32 votes and the SP about 29 votes. Senior SP leader and five-time MP Saleem Sherwani, who staked his claim and met Mr. Yadav recently, told reporters he “will not contest to lose”, implying he would not like to be the party’s third candidate.

HC raps Ravi Nair for non-disclosure of bail petition in lower court

Press Trust of India
AHMEDABAD

The Gujarat High Court on Wednesday reprimanded journalist Ravi Nair for seeking an urgent hearing on his plea against arrest in a criminal defamation suit filed by Adani Enterprises, without disclosing that he had also approached a lower court for bail. A single Bench of Justice M.K. Thakkar disposed of his plea, noting that a sessions court had already granted him bail last week. The Bench came down heavily on Mr. Nair’s counsel for seeking an urgent hearing in the High Court on September 19, without disclosing before it the fact that he had also ap-

proached the sessions court for his client’s bail. “As settled law held by the apex court...a party invoking extraordinary jurisdiction of this court is expected to approach the court with utmost candour, frankness and openness. Such a party is under obligation to disclose all material facts without any reservation, even if such facts are adverse to its case,” the HC noted in the order. Non-bailable warrant On September 24, a Gandhinagar-based appellate court released Mr. Nair on bail, a week after he was arrested following a non-bailable warrant issued against him for failing to personally appear during a hearing.

Let SIT work in peace on Veeramani case: HC

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

Observing that a SIT probing the child sexual abuse case involving R. Veeramani of Gem Granites must be allowed to work in peace, the Madras High Court on Wednesday adjourned by four weeks a plea filed by DMK to inquire Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay and Ministers Aadhav Arjuna and C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar, too, in connection with the case. Justice V. Lakshminarayanan took the decision after Advocate General Vijay Narayan pointed out that the DMK had not only filed the current petition but had also initiated a defamation suit against the two Ministers.

Cars in Odisha fined for helmets, bikes for seat belts: CAG report

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Over 2,000 two-wheelers were issued challans for seat-belt violations and more than 4,000 three- and four-wheelers were fined for failing to wear a helmet in Odisha between 2019 and 2024, according to a Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) report.

The CAG report, tabled in the Odisha Assembly on Monday, noted that at least 2,988 bike and scooter riders were fined ₹1,000 each for not wearing seat belts, while 4,786 drivers of three- and four-wheelers were fined ₹1,000 each for helmet violations under Sections 194B(I) and 194(D) of the Odisha Motor Vehicle Rules, 1993.

“Analysis of VAHAN and e-challan data pertaining to 2019-24 revealed that 2,988 cases were booked for driving vehicle ‘without seat belt’ and fine of ₹29.88 lakh was imposed whereas the vehicles were registered as two-wheelers and 4,786 cases were booked for ‘not wearing helmet’ and a total fine of ₹47.86 lakh was imposed, whereas the vehicles were registered as three and four wheelers,” the report noted.

“This indicated the casual approach of the authorities while booking the offences and lack of validation control in VAHAN, which allowed issuance of e-challans for an offence which could not have been committed by that category of vehicle,” it added.



The audit agency suggested cancellation of incorrect e-challans and action against officials. FILE PHOTO

The agency suggested corrective action, including cancellation of incorrect e-challans and action against officers responsible for issuing e-challans under incorrect sections.

Legacy waste on bikes
The CAG audited a 2022 agreement between the Rourkela Municipal Corporation and an executing agency for biomining 1.73 lakh metric tons (MT) of legacy waste at a dumpsite near Biju Patnaik University of Technology, Rourkela.

About 60,058 MT of legacy waste was shown as transported in Rourkela using two motorcycles, an e-rickshaw, a car and even a non-existent vehicle, for which ₹3.29 crore (57% of the test-checked amount) was paid to the agency, the report added.

“In the absence of a control mechanism, the audit verified the vouchers for seven months amounting to ₹5.81 crore paid for biomining of 1.06 lakh MT waste,” the agency noted in the report.

One dead and 12 injured in explosion at MRPL unit

Rupture of the cold separator operating at high pressure in the unit resulted in a fire, says firm; loud explosion heard and window panes of nearby buildings were shattered due to blast impact

The Hindu Bureau
MANGALURU

One person died, and 12 others were injured following a blast in the Coker Hydro-treater Unit of the Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Ltd. (MRPL) on the outskirts of Mangaluru on Wednesday. Among the 12, one person sustained burn injuries while the others had minor injuries.

A loud explosion was heard from the premises around noon, following which fire broke out and thick smoke was seen emanating from the refinery. Window panes of nearby buildings shattered due to the impact of the blast.

The MRPL said in a statement that rupture of the cold separator operating at high pressure in the unit resulted in a fire at



Loud explosion: Smoke erupting after the blast at the MRPL unit in Karnataka on Wednesday. PTI

about 12.20 p.m. The battery limits of the affected unit were immediately isolated and the MRPL’s emergency response and fire-fighting teams were deployed to control the situation. The fire was completely extinguished by 2.47 p.m., it said. “During

the subsequent combing and inspection operations following the firefighting activity, the body of one deceased person was found at the affected site,” the statement said.

Police Commissioner Sudheer Kumar Reddy said that the deceased, Manish

Karkada (30) from Mulky, was working on contract basis at the site. “His body was found in a charred condition,” the Commissioner said.

Another injured, identified as Rajesh Baptist, sustained 35% burn injuries and was shifted to a hospital for treatment. According to the doctors, he is out of danger and was being treated in the ICU. Eleven others, working in an office adjacent to the unit, sustained minor injuries. They were treated in the OPD, he said.

Buildings in and around Jokatte, including the gram panchayat building, witnessed tremors and window panes shattered because of the blast.

People in Angaragundi, Baikampady, Kulai and surrounding areas too experienced the tremors.

Security tightened for Keralam CM

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Security arrangements for Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan have been tightened in light of the continuing protests, primarily by Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) workers.

More police personnel, including uniformed and plainclothes officers, were deployed at venues where

the Chief Minister participated in official programmes on Wednesday.

Police personnel were positioned along routes used by the Chief Minister and Ministers. Particular attention was given to roads along the route from Cliff House, the official residence of the Chief Minister.

Nonetheless, Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha activists staged black-flag protests

against Mr. Satheesan during the wee hours of the day shortly after his arrival from New Delhi, and later in the evening.

Convoy disrupted

In both instances, the protesters attempted to disrupt the convoy and raised slogans while displaying black flags. But, the convoy proceeded without stopping.

The decision to streng-

then security was taken after a series of demonstrations targeting the Chief Minister and Ministers by BJP workers allegedly in retaliation to protests by Youth Congress activists during Union Minister Amit Shah’s visit to Kollam.

The convoys of various Ministers, including Sports and Youth Affairs Minister O.J. Janeesh, were obstructed a day ago.

INBRIEF



Two A.P. college PG students found dead within five days

Two postgraduate students of Andhra Medical College in Visakhapatnam, one in her final year and the other in her first, have allegedly died by suicide within five days. The police are conducting a detailed inquiry into both deaths. On September 24, P. Sailaja, a final-year postgraduate student, died at her residence. Her family told the police that career-related stress could have been a factor. On September 28, Y. Sravani, a first-year ENT student, died in her rented accommodation. She had not wanted to continue with the course, according to the police. The two incidents have raised questions about the pressures faced by PG students. (Those in distress can call: Tele MANAS 14416)

‘Dead’ for 13 years, accused in narcotics cases held in A.P.

A 56-year-old man, accused in multiple narcotics cases and believed to have died while living under an assumed identity, was arrested by the Kannur City police from Andhra Pradesh after 13 years. The arrested person is K.T. Jose alias Korra Josh Babu, a native of Iritty in Kannur district of Kerala. Accused in drug cases, he reportedly failed to appear before the court in a case in 2008 and was declared a proclaimed offender by the Vadakara NDPS court in 2013.

HC reserves order on plea seeking FIR against Pinarayi

The Kerala High Court on Wednesday reserved its verdict in a petition seeking the registration of an FIR and investigation by the State Police Chief into the predicate offence found during an Enforcement Directorate probe in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case. Justice A. Badharudeen observed orally that the question of whether to conduct a preliminary inquiry before registering an FIR would have to be analysed on “a case-to-case basis.”

Flying colours



Fire drill: A dog in action during the passing out parade of the 23rd batch of canines and handlers at the 6th Battalion of Andhra Pradesh Special Police at Mangalagiri in Guntur district, on Wednesday. K.V.S. GIRI

DoorDash opens its office in Hyderabad; to create 3,000 jobs

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

DoorDash, one of the leading local commerce platforms globally, opened its first India office in Hyderabad on Wednesday with plans to hire 500 people initially for the facility and raise the number over time to 3,000.

It will draw on Hyderabad’s deep talent pool and technology ecosystem while creating long-term career opportunities, the NASDAQ-listed firm said following inauguration of the office, which it calls Talent Hub, by IT and Industries Minister D. Sridhar Babu in the presence of CFO Ravi Inukonda, senior director, Workforce Strategy and Talent Acquisition

Operations Jenna Kohnke. The Hyderabad hub will be DoorDash’s third internal Customer Experience and Integrity (CXI) service centre globally, alongside those in Tempe, Arizona, and Mexico City. It will support global operations and help deliver reliable experiences for consumers, merchants and ‘Dashers’ across DoorDash’s geographies. The Minister’s office said the firm will scale its headcount, at the facility, to more than 3,000 within the next two years. “Establishing DoorDash’s first hub in India is an important milestone in expanding our global operations network,” said Ms. Kohnke. It will start operations in Hyderabad in October.

12 members of U.P. family rescued from alleged bonded labour in Hyderabad

Naveen Kumar
HYDERABAD

A family of migrants workers from Uttar Pradesh, who were allegedly assaulted and prevented from leaving the premises of a construction facility they were working in Telangana, were rescued on Tuesday.

Nearly a year after they arrived in Hyderabad for work, Revenue and Labour officials from Medchal-Malkajgiri district rescued all 12 members of the family from alleged bonded labour conditions at the facility in Bachupally.

Among those rescued were six children aged between three and 10. During the inspection, officials found four women, aged 40, 25, 20 and 19, and the children living in tin-sheet



Women and children were among the members of the Uttar Pradesh family who were rescued on Tuesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

rooms without ventilation. The family cooked and defecated inside these rooms.

Received complaints

The rescue followed a complaint by social workers to the Revenue Divisional Officer, Medchal-Malkajgiri district. The migrant workers told officials that they

SIR: filled Form-7s targeting Muslims surface in Belagavi

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

“For at least the last 15 years, I have been the Booth Level Agent here at polling station 196 in Belagavi North Assembly constituency. But last week, when I saw at least 380 Form-7 applications at the school, I was shocked to find my name and my brother’s, along with those of our relatives and neighbours, sought to be deleted,” said Meersab Sanadi, BLA at Veerabhadra Urdu Model School in Belagavi’s 7th Cross, where he is also the chairman.

The incident, in which “already printed” bulk Form-7 applications seeking deletion of Muslim names were received by Booth Level Officers (BLOs), was reported in at least six polling stations in Belagavi North Assembly constituency – four in Veerabhadra Nagar (polling parts 194, 195, 196 and 199) and two in the Government Kannada Higher Primary School in Shettigalli (polling parts 209 and 210).

BLOs at these stations told *The Hindu* that two men, claiming to be from the Belagavi City Corporation, brought a bulk of Form-7 applications seeking deletion of only Muslim names. The voters’ names and other details were pre-filled, while the objectors’ names were either handwritten or left blank.

The men allegedly repeatedly told the BLOs that the applications had to be

ERO Udayakumar Basavantappa Talawar says someone falsely used his name

signed and returned urgently. The BLOs, however, refused, saying they knew the electors whose names appeared on the forms as that they had been living in the area for years. When the BLOs continued to refuse, the men allegedly called someone over the phone who posed as Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) Udayakumar Basavantappa Talawar and instructed them to sign the applications.

ERO Mr. Talawar told *The Hindu* that someone had falsely used his name and that he had not issued any such instructions.

Under pressure, some BLOs said they signed the forms, while others said they tried to contact their supervisors and the Assistant Electoral Registration Officer, but could not reach them.

Meanwhile, the trend of seeking deletions of Muslim voters’ names continued in Bhalki even after the claims and objections period ended on September 23, with people who had filed Form-7 applications in bulk before the deadline continuing to file applications. Applications filed after the claims and objections period will be taken up only after the final electoral roll is published.

BJP slams Telangana CM, says he wants to divide Hindu society

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The BJP on Wednesday accused the Congress and Telangana Chief Minister Revanth Reddy of seeking to divide Hindu society along regional, linguistic, caste, and gender lines, while referring to Mr. Reddy’s remarks on Lord Shiva and Lord Rama.

At a press conference, BJP MP and spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi alleged that the Congress pursued the politics of “divide Hindus for the Muslim rule”.

Countering Mr. Reddy’s comments, made at an

event on Monday, he said that the Congress wanted to divide Hindu society into South and North.

“The same Telangana CM is himself saying now that ‘we are Dravidian, they are Aryans’. It is such a foolish, baseless theory, which has now been rejected throughout the world,” he said.

“They want to split us into provinces. This same Mr. Reddy had spoken about the DNA of Bihar and the DNA of Telangana. Then after that, they want to divide us on the basis of language and then caste,” he said.

The workers said they were not allowed to leave the premises together as a family and that most of their belongings were kept in a separate room locked by a supervisor.

Sick and injured workers were allegedly not provided adequate medical treatment. One worker told officials that he had been physically assaulted on multiple occasions.

The case is being examined under the Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act, 1976, in view of allegations of withheld wages, restrictions on movement, physical violence, threats and the workers’ inability to freely leave their employment.

When contacted, Candour constructions was not available for a comment or statement.



Good foundation

The festive season looks set to build on months of strong industrial growth

India's industrial growth performance in August continued its strong streak since the beginning of the financial year, and sets the economy up well for the upcoming festive season. Growth in the Index of Industrial Production (IIP) quickened to 8% in August 2026, the second fastest that it has been since at least April 2024, which is the earliest month for which the new series of the IIP has growth data. The fastest growth in this period, of 8.8%, came as recently as June 2026. In fact, IIP growth in the April-August period of this financial year stood at a robust 6.8%, faster than that seen during the corresponding periods of the previous two years. The new series has an updated base year, more data sources, and improved methodology, so this growth performance is as accurate an indication of industrial growth as government data can provide. Moreover, apart from a few divergences, IIP data largely match the trends evident in the Index of Core Industries (ICI), the other government index that measures industrial performance. For example, the IIP shows that the electricity sector's growth quickened to 12.3% in August 2026, while the ICI pegs it at 11.6%. Similarly, the construction goods sector saw growth come in at a relatively strong 6.4%, albeit slower than July's 8%. In keeping with that, the ICI shows that the cement sector grew by a robust 12.5% in August, though this was slightly slower than the 12.7% in July. The older series of both indices often provided contrary indications, so this alignment is welcome.

The IIP for August also lays out some core strengths that seem to be developing in the economy. The manufacturing sector grew by nearly 9% in August, and averaged 7.6% in the April-August 2026 period. Given that it had grown by about 4.2% in the first five months of the previous financial year, this acceleration is good to see, especially since it comes at a time when producers are facing several input-related pressures. At the start of this calendar year, manufacturing growth seemed to have been driven by a growth in exports. The August data show that this is now being supplemented by a recovery in domestic consumption. The growth in consumer durables stood at 11.1% in August. The consumer non-durables sector returned to growth, of a little more than 2%, after having contracted in July. The effect of the Goods and Services Tax rate cuts in September 2025 should have petered out by now, so this boost in durables production likely means that producers are expecting a strong festive season ahead. The third quarter of the financial year will therefore be crucial for the economy, but the groundwork seems to be in place for a relatively good one.

Bitter pills

The Supreme Court did well to intervene in drug pricing by retailers

The Supreme Court has upbraided disparities between the price to retailer (PTR) and the maximum retail price (MPR) of certain drugs, including those used to treat cancers, in some instances up to 1,000%. These drugs are not available over-the-counter, so hospitals often control which brand a patient uses. As a result, pharmaceutical companies compete for the hospitals' business, not patients'. To incentivise a hospital to stock specific drugs, they deliberately specify inflated MRPs while offering the hospital low PTRs, and the hospital can pocket the difference. The practice does not technically amount to a kickback but is one economically, as manufacturers effectively promise hospitals an embedded financial reward to pick specific products, and leave patients to potentially pay more than the medicines' supply price because hospitals have an incentive to sell brands with the largest margins. When private hospitals also force patients to purchase drugs from on-premise pharmacies – as Competition Commission investigations have established – patients are unable to shop around, undermining normal price competition. So, more affordable equivalent drugs are disadvantaged because of their lower revenue generation potential for hospitals. Patients, meanwhile, face severe financial strain – a concern also flagged by drug regulators in Karnataka and Maharashtra – and could, among those with cancers and chronic conditions, reduce adherence to longer treatment regimens.

The practice arises from a gap in the 2013 Drug (Prices Control) Order, which caps the final maximum price of scheduled drugs, but not the markup on hospitals' transactions. Say the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) calculates the market-derived average price of such a drug to be ₹100, making the ceiling ₹116. If a hospital negotiates a PTR of ₹50 from the manufacturer, it can still sell the drug (or bill the government if a drug is state-financed) at ₹116, without breaching the ceiling, and enjoy the difference of ₹66. In a proof-of-concept exercise in 2019, the NPPA capped the trade margins of 42 non-schedule anti-cancer drugs at 30%. The Department of Pharmaceuticals subsequently said prices of 526 brands dropped by up to 91%, suggesting that the MRPs of several cancer drugs included compressible margins. Second, while the Court's suggestion to have a fixed percentage markup across all drugs is appealing, it should accompany a regressive margin that applies a smaller percentage as drug prices increase, to neutralise sellers' incentive to favour more expensive products. Overall, however, the Court is right to highlight this insidious problem, especially after refusing to intervene in *Siddharth Dalmia* (2025), and while the Union and States have failed to counterbalance the absence of natural market mechanisms to rationalise drug prices.

On October 1, 2025, the Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA) between India and the four European Free Trade Association (EFTA) states – Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway and Switzerland – entered into force. One year on, the more useful question is not how many tariff lines have fallen, but what kind of partnership the agreement is making possible.

The tariff figures are substantial. EFTA states have offered concessions on 92.2% of their tariff lines, covering 99.6% of the value of India's exports to them. India, in turn, is granting concessions on 82.7% of its tariff lines, covering 95.3% of the value of EFTA's exports. Few market-opening exercises between India and a group of developed economies have been this ambitious.

Lasting partnerships, an India focus

Yet, the defining feature of TEPA lies elsewhere. It was the first trade agreement that India signed with a dedicated chapter on investment and job creation. Under it, the EFTA states aim to raise investment in India by \$100 billion over 15 years and to facilitate one million direct jobs. An agreement based on that is designed to build lasting industrial and technological partnerships.

For a country of just under 4,00,000 people, Iceland's contribution to that partnership was never going to be about scale. It is about experience, particularly in three areas where that experience speaks directly to India's priorities.

The first is geothermal energy, specifically a part of it that receives far less attention than power generation: the direct use of low- to medium-temperature heat. In Iceland, geothermal energy heats nearly every home, dries fish, warms greenhouses and keeps entire communities running through Arctic winters without burning fossil fuels. That century of experience in direct use is what the Himalayan geothermal belt of northern India can draw on.

Consider the apple growers of Himachal Pradesh. Many have long been forced to sell their harvest immediately, at the lowest prices of the season, because they lacked the means to store their crops.

That is now changing. At Tapri, in Kinnaur district, a geothermal facility operated by Geotropy, an Indian-Icelandic venture, uses heat drawn from the ground to dry fruit, and this harvest season, it is running round the clock as growers line up to use it.

A geothermal cooling facility at the same site is due to be completed by the end of the year. Farmers there can now process their produce



Benedikt Höskuldsson

The Ambassador of Iceland to India

and time their sales rather than remain price-takers at harvest, drawing on the same direct-use techniques that Iceland has refined over generations. Or consider the high-altitude communities and installations along India's northern frontier, which depend on fuel hauled along supply lines that can close for months. Heat drawn directly from the ground beneath them offers something no convoy can: energy security that does not depend on the road remaining open.

The second area is carbon capture, utilisation and storage. A NITI Aayog study in 2022 estimated that India could capture some 750 million tonnes of carbon dioxide a year by 2050. The scientific foundations are being laid by the Department of Science and Technology, which has steered India's carbon capture, utilisation and storage (CCUS) research for years and, in December 2025, published the country's first dedicated research and development road map for CCUS in support of the 2070 net-zero goal.

The Union Budget followed in February with an outlay of ₹20,000 crore over five years to take these technologies towards scale in power, steel, cement, refining and chemicals, while public sector companies such as the Oil and Natural Gas Corporation, NTPC Limited (formerly National Thermal Power Corporation) and Indian Oil Corporation Limited are taking the work into the field through feasibility studies, pilot projects and subsurface assessments.

This pre-commercial stage is exactly where Iceland's experience is most valuable, on both sides of the equation. On storage, CarbFix has shown that when carbon dioxide is dissolved in water and injected into basalt, more than 95% of it turns to stone within two years; India's Deccan Trap basalts share striking geological similarities with Iceland's volcanic rock.

New frontiers

On utilisation, Iceland was home to the world's first industrial-scale plant to turn captured carbon dioxide into fuel: Carbon Recycling International's George Olah plant at Svartsengi, which began producing methanol in 2011-12. Its technology now operates on a far larger scale abroad, including in projects involving steel-sector emissions. In May, Carbon Iceland signed a memorandum of understanding with JSW Steel and Bharatya to explore a 3,00,000-tonne-a-year e-methanol project in Raigad, Maharashtra, converting steel-plant emissions into fuel using green hydrogen. The opportunity, therefore, lies less in exporting equipment than in sharing knowledge and

An ambitious India-Europe partnership can deliver across trade, technology, energy and Arctic stewardship

Household debt, financing today against tomorrow



M. Suresh Babu

Director, Madras Institute of Development Studies, Chennai

informal-sector employee or casual worker faces a very different risk profile. The RBI has noted that consumption-oriented borrowing remains significant, although its growth has moderated, while borrowing for productive purposes has been increasing. This should be welcomed, but should not obscure the distributional dimension of household indebtedness.

The fundamental question is why households are borrowing. If borrowing increases because incomes are rising and households are investing in houses, education or productive assets, higher indebtedness need not necessarily be a source of concern. But if borrowing is required to finance food, health care, education, housing rents, durable goods or other routine expenditures because current incomes are inadequate, debt becomes a mechanism for postponing rather than resolving the income constraint.

Digital lending platforms, instant personal loans, app-based credit and online consumer finance have substantially reduced the transaction costs associated with borrowing. The boundary between what a household can afford and what it can borrow becomes blurred. At the macroeconomic level, consumption financed through credit can support aggregate demand. At the household level, however, the same process creates future repayment obligations. When households borrow to finance health care, education, housing or old-age needs, debt is effectively substituting for inadequate social protection. In this sense, household debt is not merely an outcome of individual financial choices. It is shaped by the institutional structure of the economy.

The macroeconomic implications

Household debt has implications beyond individual borrowers. In the short run, credit expansion can stimulate consumption and support economic growth. But excessive household leverage can eventually have the opposite effect. As debt-servicing obligations rise, households reduce discretionary expenditure. Consumption becomes increasingly sensitive to

interest rates and employment conditions. The macroeconomic transmission mechanism is straightforward: Income stagnation, borrowing to sustain consumption, rising debt service, declining disposable income, weaker consumption, greater dependence on credit.

If this cycle becomes entrenched, credit ceases to be an instrument for productive investment and becomes a mechanism for sustaining consumption in the face of inadequate income growth. There is therefore a potential contradiction between credit-led consumption growth and income-led demand expansion.

The first can generate a temporary acceleration of demand. The second provides a more sustainable foundation. The policy response to rising household debt should not be simply to restrict lending. Credit is an essential component of economic development, and access to formal credit can substantially improve household welfare. The challenge is to distinguish productive credit from distress credit and asset-building borrowing from consumption smoothing under income pressure.

What the central issue is

India's household debt story is therefore more complicated than the headline number suggests. The government has emphasised that India's household leverage remains below that of many emerging-market peers and that household net financial savings have improved. But the central issue is not simply how much households owe. It is why they owe it, to whom they owe it, at what cost, and against what income.

The danger lies in confusing access to credit with improvement in economic welfare. The more unequal and uncertain incomes become, the greater the temptation to finance living standards through borrowing. The question before policymakers is therefore not merely how to regulate household debt, but how to build an economy in which households can live on their incomes rather than against their future incomes.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

SIR debate, electoral trust

With the top court upholding the validity of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) conducted in Bihar, and the Election Commission clarifying its position on the exercise and stating that its decisions were taken unanimously, the legal position on the SIR has been substantially settled. It is difficult to understand why the Opposition and some

television channels continue to question the exercise. Voters have exercised their franchise in favour of both the National Democratic Alliance and the Opposition in different elections. Where, then, is the justification for questioning the Chief Election Commissioner when a party loses an election? Earlier, the Electronic Voting Machine was blamed; now the Chief

Election Commissioner is being questioned. It is undeniable that voters consider their sense of security and the quality of leadership when making their electoral choices.

S. Seshadri,
Chennai

Celebrating victory

I write this letter as a former Deputy General Manager (Sports Department), Rashtriya Ispat Nigam

Limited (RINL), Visakhapatnam Steel Plant (VSP). Whenever athletes win medals at major international sporting events, photographers frequently ask them to hold the medal between their teeth and pose. Indian sportspersons have also increasingly followed this international practice. The medal-biting pose is mainly a modern sports photography tradition. It is

sometimes associated with the old image of biting gold to test its authenticity. However, modern Olympic gold medals are not made of solid gold, and there is no sporting rule requiring an athlete to bite a medal. Could India develop its own dignified and distinctive way of celebrating sporting success? For example, Indian medal winners could be encouraged to hold the medal near their heart, raise

it proudly alongside the Indian Tricolour, salute the National Flag, or adopt another respectful pose representing India's cultural identity. There is nothing wrong with following an international photographic tradition, but there can be a change.

J.L.V. Sastry,
Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

In U.P., the Congress needs the SP

As Uttar Pradesh heads toward its next Assembly contest, Congress strategists are dealing with an uncomfortable truth: in the current alliance, the Samajwadi Party (SP) holds the stronger hand. Beyond the optics of ‘INDIA bloc unity’, the arithmetic and organisational depth point the same way: the Congress needs the SP more than the SP needs the Congress.

The first distinction is structural. The SP is not a personality-led outfit that borrows crowds for a season and vanishes when the tide turns. It has a functioning cadre and booth-level workers; Yadav-Muslim social capital built over three decades; a growing share of non-Yadav Other Backward Classes (OBCs) and Dalits; and a district-to-village skeleton that survives bad election cycles. Compare this to the Trinamool Congress or the Aam Aadmi Party which is based on ‘leader-and-supporter’ constructs; they are formidable when the leader is popular but structurally thin once the wave recedes.

The Congress’s State unit suffers from the ailment the SP has cured. It is a supporter-driven shell, dependent on media cycles, occasional Rahul Gandhi yatras, and transient online support, lacking ground infrastructure to convert sentiment into votes on polling day. The SP’s cadre, by contrast, is a durable asset that isn’t going anywhere regardless of who wins in 2027; that permanence is the leverage.

The second argument, arguably more decisive, is vote arithmetic. U.P.’s contest is no longer a fragmented four-cornered



Syed Kamran

Independent journalist and political commentator based in Lucknow

fight; it has hardened into a bipolar contest between the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the SP-led opposition. The Bahujan Samaj Party’s (BSP) vote share has been steadily eroding, and what remains of it, along with residual anti-BJP sentiment scattered across smaller caste-based and regional outfits, has no natural home. It flows toward whichever non-BJP formation has the most chance of winning.

In a bipolar contest, that residual “anyone but the BJP” vote doesn’t split evenly; it consolidates behind the party seen as the real challenger, and in U.P. that is unambiguously the SP, not the Congress. Voters unhappy with the BJP will vote strategically by gravitating to the SP because it has repeatedly shown itself as the only outfit within striking distance of the BJP’s vote share. The Congress, hovering in single digits across most U.P. assembly segments for over a decade, isn’t part of that calculation for the median opposition voter. Its vote-multiplying value is limited, while the SP’s brand pulls in the anti-incumbency vote that decides seats.

The third argument is narrative ownership. The 2027 U.P. election is shaping Akhilesh Yadav as the face of the opposition and the PDA (*Pichda*, Dalit, *Alpsankhyak* (Backward, Dalit, Minority)) as the organising social coalition. This has been Mr. Yadav’s framework since the 2022 defeat, and it has visibly reshaped how backward and Dalit voters outside the traditional SP base view the party. The Congress has no competing narrative in U.P. with similar traction; its national Nyay (justice) framework and Bharat Jodo-adjacent

messaging hasn’t localised into a U.P.-specific story the way the PDA has.

When one partner owns the narrative and the other is borrowing space within it, the question of who ‘steers the wheel’ answers itself. A realistic path for the Congress lies in being a disciplined junior partner that helps consolidate the PDA coalition in seats where it adds value, such as in Brahmin and urban pockets, rather than insisting on parity in seat-sharing. Overreach risks fracturing an already-fragile anti-BJP consolidation.

The bottom line

This does not mean that the Congress brings nothing to the table; a national party’s symbolic weight does have marginal value. But marginal value is not equal leverage in a State as diverse as U.P. The SP has cadre permanence, the bipolar arithmetic that captures residual anti-BJP votes, and narrative ownership through Mr. Yadav and the PDA. In any honest reading, this is an alliance where one partner can survive alone and the other cannot; and that imbalance should shape how the Congress negotiates seats and its place in the coalition.

The Congress’s best bet is to fight this election in alliance with the SP with realistic seat demands rather than inflated ones – concentrating resources on a limited set of seats. A good strike rate on fewer seats does two things: it hands the Congress a stronger hand in seat-sharing talks for 2029, and it gives the party a real bloc of sitting MLAs; the kind of ground presence no amount of central leadership visibility can substitute for.

How to finance rural prosperity

India’s agricultural transformation is one of the greatest achievements of independent India. Over the past six decades, the nation has emerged as one of the world’s largest producers of cereals, milk, fruits, vegetables and fisheries products. This progress was driven by visionary public policy, scientific innovation, irrigation, institutional credit and the enterprise of millions of Indian farmers.

While India’s first agricultural transformation delivered food security, the next must deliver rural prosperity by enabling rural India to capture a larger share of the value created after harvest. Every agricultural commodity passes through a value chain from production to aggregation, storage, logistics, processing, branding and markets. It is along this chain that enterprises emerge, employment expands and prosperity grows. Financing this change requires moving past production credit towards financing the entire agricultural value chain.

Dairy, poultry and fisheries operate through continuous procurement and marketing cycles, generating predictable cash flows, lower inventory risks and regular working-capital turnover. However, seasonal commodities operate under a very different financial reality. Processors need to procure most of their annual raw material requirement within a short harvest window and finance inventory for the remainder of the year. A company investing ₹500 crore in a modern processing facility may require ₹700–₹800 crore simply to procure, store and carry seasonal inventory.



Sanjay Agarwal

Former Secretary, Department of Agriculture & Farmers Welfare, Government of India

Without appropriately structured working capital, even efficient enterprises struggle to remain commercially viable. While the sugar sector is also seasonal, its growth demonstrates how inventory finance and warehouse-backed lending can overcome seasonal constraints. The difference in sector growth lies not in production potential but in the way the chain is financed.

Need for new mechanisms

For more than five decades, successive reforms including bank nationalisation, rural banks, cooperative institutions and the Kisan credit card expanded production credit. India has successfully built robust institutions for financing agricultural production when national food security was the priority. It must now build robust mechanisms for financing every commercially viable activity that creates value between the farm and the final consumer.

Encouragingly, elements of such a financing ecosystem are already emerging. Banks have introduced products such as warehouse receipt financing, receivables financing, and financing for food processing and agricultural infrastructure, while agri-focused non-banking financial companies have pioneered innovative value-chain models. However, these remain isolated initiatives rather than components of a comprehensive agricultural value chain financing architecture.

The opportunity is substantial. Based on the difference between the GVA (Gross Value Added) of agriculture and allied sectors (₹48.8 lakh crore) and the institutional credit flow (₹20

lakh crore) during 2023-24, indicative estimates suggest that the financing opportunity across India’s agricultural value chains could exceed ₹14 lakh crore.

While only about 10-12% of agricultural produce is processed in India, the corresponding level is estimated at around 35–45% across East, South and Southeast Asia and often exceeds 60% in many developed economies. In these economies, agricultural transformation is supported by financing systems aligned with commodity-specific value chains rather than production alone.

A comprehensive agricultural value chain financing framework should provide a diverse portfolio of financial instruments, including product finance, receivables finance, warehouse receipt finance, risk mitigation solutions and credit enhancement mechanisms. These instruments can finance the flow of goods, services and capital across the value chain, with financing decisions increasingly based on commodity-specific value chains and cash-flow analysis rather than conventional collateral alone. This will enable capital to reach farmers, input suppliers, aggregators, warehouse operators, processors, logistics providers, exporters and retailers, thereby unlocking private investment, creating rural jobs, improving farmer incomes, and accelerating rural industrialisation.

Building a solid agricultural value chain finance architecture can become one of the most consequential reforms for achieving the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047.

Rise in EV adoption stresses need for ramping up charging infra

Three-wheeler EVs accounted for the States of Assam, Bihar, West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh showing higher figures in EV adoption

DATA POINT

Sachin Swaraj
Pon Vasanth B.A.

India is slowly but steadily transitioning towards Electric Vehicles (EVs), with cars under the “alternative fuels” category overtaking petrol cars for the first time in August 2026, as per the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations’ (FADA).

Though the alternative fuels category included fuel types such as CNG/LPG, the overall growth in the sale of EVs was significant, as reported by *The Hindu*.

However, State-wise data shows that this growth is not uniform with notable variations even among comparable States. **Table 1** shows the share of EVs and hybrid EVs in the total registrations of all types of vehicles since 2022-23. Only the States and Union Territories (UTs) that registered at least 10,000 EVs (including hybrids) are shown in the table. As the data shows, the first five months of 2026-27 have already seen a significant increase with 12.7% (16.5 lakh) of the roughly 1.29 crore vehicles registered in India being EVs or hybrids. Among the major States and UTs, Keralam, Delhi, Karnataka, Odisha, and Telangana are leading with at least 15% of the registered vehicles being EVs or hybrids.

While Keralam, Delhi, and Karnataka were already showing notable increases in the previous years as well, data shows that the near doubling of the share in Telangana was mainly driven by the three-wheeler segment. Three-wheeler EVs also accounted for Assam, Bihar, West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh showing higher figures. The share of EVs and hybrids in new registrations in 2026-27 will drop to well below 5% if three-wheelers are excluded, analysis showed. Tripura and Assam will drop to the lowest of 2.2% and 2.6% if three-wheelers are excluded.

The disparity between the States and UTs in EV adoption is also visible in terms of availability of EV charging infrastructure and the power consumption from EV charging stations.

Chart 1 shows the power consumption from public charging stations, excluding the heavy-duty ones predominantly used by government-operated e-buses, based on the Central Electricity Authority’s report for the financial year 2025-26. Among the 15 States/UTs with highest power consumption shown in the chart, Maharashtra outperformed other States in both the availability of number of charging locations and their usage measured by the power consumed.

While Delhi showed high usage despite relatively fewer number of charging stations, Karnataka was at the other end with highest number of charging locations but relatively lesser usage. All the other States shown in the chart lagged behind by a wide margin when compared with Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, Karnataka and Maharashtra. The map shows whether the charging infrastructure available in public places has grown in proportion to the number of EVs registered across India. It measures how many newly registered EVs share charging infrastructure in a public place. For instance, there is one charging location available for every 997 registered EVs in Assam. Karnataka, on the other hand, has a public charging facility for every 144 EVs registered between 2021-22 and 2026-27 (till August) – indicating the need for the charging infrastructure to grow in places that are adopting quickly to EVs.

Although the map does not show the concentration of the charging facilities within each State, analysis showed they are heavily concentrated in and around major urban centres. For instance, Karnataka has public charging facilities in around 6,000 locations, of which about two-thirds are located in and around Bengaluru.

Uneven growth

The data for the analysis were sourced from Vahan portal, Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE) and the Central Electricity Authority (CEA). Data on charging stations sourced from BEE is as of late 2025. Sachin Swaraj is interning with The Hindu’s Data team

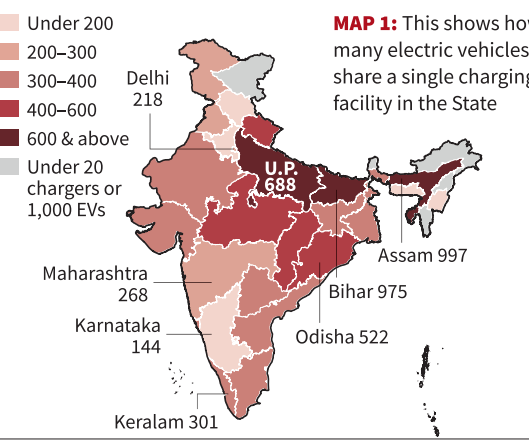
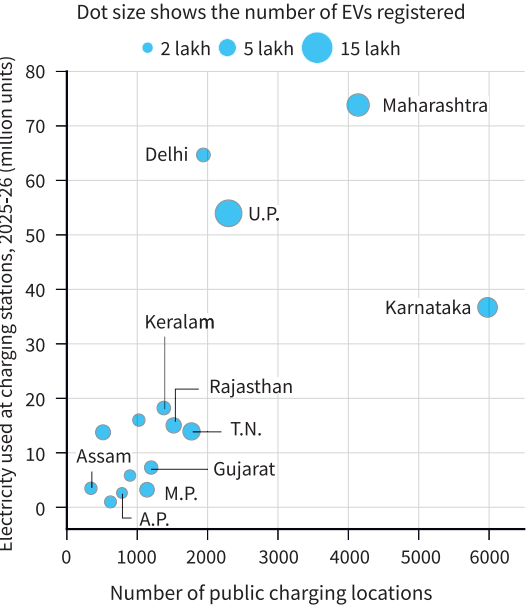


TABLE 1: This shows the share of electric vehicles (EVs) and hybrid EVs in the total number of vehicles registered. Only those States and UTs that registered at least 10,000 EVs and hybrid EVs in 2025-26 are shown

State	2022-23	2023-24	2024-25	2025-26	2026-27*
Uttar Pradesh	6.9	9.5	10.9	10.6	12.6
Maharashtra	7.7	9.5	9.6	9.2	13.1
Karnataka	8.6	11.1	11.1	12.7	16.5
Tamil Nadu	5.3	6.7	8.5	9.7	12.9
Madhya Pradesh	3.9	5.8	7.2	9.5	12.6
Keralam	8.7	13.7	14.1	15.5	18.0
West Bengal	2.2	3.4	5.2	10.6	11.6
Bihar	5.8	7.7	8.7	8.6	11.2
Rajasthan	7.4	7.1	7.4	7.6	11.8
Delhi	13.5	15.3	14.7	15.2	17.0
Gujarat	6.1	5.8	4.8	4.9	7.3
Odisha	6.1	7.8	9.3	10.9	18.7
Assam	9.0	10.9	12.4	17.0	20.7
Telangana	4.2	6.3	7.2	8.4	15.1
Andhra Pradesh	4.9	5.1	7.2	7.9	12.4
Punjab	4.6	7.0	8.5	7.7	10.2
Chhattisgarh	6.7	8.5	8.3	8.5	12.7
Haryana	5.8	6.4	6.7	5.7	6.2
Jharkhand	4.3	5.1	5.7	6.4	8.5
Uttarakhand	8.4	8.3	8.8	8.8	11.8
Jammu & Kashmir	4.9	8.5	9.7	8.3	10.3
Goa	12.1	17.0	16.1	14.7	20.1
Tripura	8.8	12.7	16.3	18.4	20.0
All India	6.4	8.1	8.8	9.5	12.7

Share (%) of EV + hybrid in all new vehicle registrations. Lightest shade is <5. Other bands are 5-8%, 8-11%, 11-14%, >14%

CHART 1: This shows the power consumed from public charging stations, when compared with the number of locations in which such infrastructure is available



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The *Hindu*

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 1, 1976

Southern rice zone minus Kerala

New Delhi, September 30: The formation of a southern rice zone, comprising Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Pondicherry, was announced to-day by the Union Minister for Agriculture and Irrigation, Mr. Jagjivan Ram. Kerala will not be in the zone because as Mr. Jagjivan Ram said, “we take the responsibility of supplying the requirements of Kerala from the Central pool.”

Within the zone there would be no curbs on movement of rice.

The northern rice zone will be expanded to include Rajasthan. At present, it consists of Punjab, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir and Delhi.

Also, there is no change in regard to the kharif cereals other than rice – there will be no restriction on the movement in the country.

Mr. Jagjivan Ram made these points at a press conference, called to announce the kharif policy on the basis of the recommendations of the Agricultural Prices Commission. The Union Cabinet, which considered the Commission’s report this morning, Mr. Jagjivan Ram said, decided to accept its suggestion that the procurement prices of coarse paddy be continued at Rs. 74 per quintal for the coming season. Similarly, the procurement rates of other coarse cereals will remain at Rs. 74 per quintal. The Cabinet, however, decided to reduce the procurement target of rice from 5.5 million tonnes, as recommended by the Commission, to 4.4 million tonnes.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 1, 1926

Poisoning prevented by wireless

London, September 30: The wireless search for Mr. Penn (see message issued yesterday) has ended happily. This afternoon the purchaser of the pills, telegraphed to the Chemist from London where he read of the mistake in a London newspaper, that none of the pills had yet been taken. The pills contained 1/4 grain of Strychnine each, instead of 1/40. The announcement has greatly relieved the chemist, who, upon the discovery of his error, had telegraphed a warning to every Mr. Penn in the directory.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Amount received by Mizoram under the Centre's schemes

75.79 in ₹ crore. Mizoram received ₹75.79 crore under central schemes to develop the agriculture sector of the State, an official statement said on Wednesday. Agriculture Minister Shivrāj Singh Chouhan handed over the release orders to State Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare Minister P.C. Vanlalruata in New Delhi on Tuesday. PTI

Community halls to be turned into Ayushman Arogya Mandirs

78 The Municipal Corporation of Delhi will set up Ayushman Arogya Mandirs (AyAMs) in its community halls across the capital to strengthen primary healthcare accessibility for local residents, officials said. Under the initiative led by the MCD's health department, 78 under-utilised civic halls will host primary health centres under the centrally sponsored scheme. PTI

Number of women executed in the U.S. since 1976

18 The U.S. state of Tennessee was set on Wednesday to execute a woman for the first time in 200 years, three decades after she murdered a classmate. Christa Pike, now 50, was 18 when she and her boyfriend beat and killed Colleen Slemmer, 19, at a job training camp for young people. In the United States, only 18 women have been executed since 1976, the Center says. AFP

Percentage decline in seaborne imports of motor fuels to Russia

24 in per cent. Seaborne imports of motor fuels to Russia fell by about 24% month-on-month in September to 350,000 metric tons, while Moscow continued to struggle with oil products shortages, sources said. The main bulk of seaborne fuel imports into Russian ports in September consisted of gasoline supplied from India, Morocco and Türkiye, traders said. REUTERS

Union government's fiscal deficit at the end of August

7.1 in ₹ lakh crore. The Union government's fiscal deficit stood at ₹7.1 lakh crore or 41.9% of the full-year target at the end of August, according to data released by the Controller General of Accounts (CGA) on Wednesday. The deficit was at 38.1% of the Budget Estimates (BE) of 2025-26 during the corresponding period last year. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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The significance of the Cardiff MoU

The Memorandum of Understanding signals growing demands for autonomy in Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland, though their constitutional goals differ; it also calls for closer ties with the EU, putting pressure on Westminster to address their aspirations

WORLD INSIGHT

Joan Sony Cherian

In September 14, the First Ministers of Northern Ireland, Wales and Scotland came together in Cardiff, the capital city of Wales, to sign a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) and declared, “For the first time ever, people across these islands have First Ministers...who are all committed to independence from the United Kingdom. For people watching across these islands – for people watching around the world – there could be no clearer sign that Westminster’s time is coming to an end.” The MoU is being seen as a significant political statement by all three parties towards constitutional independence from the U.K.

The U.K. is often described as a multi-national state (or a State of Unions), developed gradually over several centuries. As per the Cabinet Office, the U.K. is comprised of four ‘nations’ – England, Wales, Scotland and Northern Ireland.

The nations of Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland have strong cultural identities, their own language and customs as well as complicated histories vis-a-vis England, marked by conquests and rebellions. It is owing to such strong assertions of identity and independence that these nations within the U.K. have been granted varying degrees of self-government and devolved powers. However, calls for independence or an absolute devolution of powers have always remained in public discourse, and today, with the leaders of all three nations being vocal proponents of self-determination, the mandate has been brought to Westminster in full force.

However, independence does not look the same for all three nations; it’s characterised by their specific contexts, histories and geopolitical locations.

The Irish question

Northern Ireland is governed by a power-sharing agreement known as consociationalism, as laid down in the Good Friday Agreement of 1998. Considering the tumultuous history of violence between the pro-Irish (Nationalists or Republicans) and pro-Union (Loyalists or Unionists) groups, consociationalism mandates that power should be shared between all sectarian groups equally. Therefore, both the Nationalist and the Unionist blocs need to hold power together. After elections, the largest party in the largest political bloc will hold the position of First Minister, while the largest party in the second-largest political bloc can have the post of Deputy First Minister. Currently, Sinn Féin, the largest Nationalist party, is in power, with its Vice-President, Michelle O’Neill, leading the country.

However, pro-Irish groups in Northern Ireland and Sinn Féin do not wish for independence; they wish to unite with the Republic of Ireland. Owing to such strong sympathies, the Good Friday Agreement has a clause which keeps this option open – that the people of Northern Ireland could seek reunification with Ireland any time, subject to a referendum. However, a referendum can be called only by the U.K. Secretary of State for Northern Ireland if no other referendum has taken place in the past seven years or if the Secretary thinks that a majority of people wish to leave the U.K. and join Ireland.

The Unionists have strongly pushed



(From left) Scotland’s John Swinney, Wales’ Rhun ap Iorwerth, Sinn Féin’s Mary Lou McDonald and Northern Ireland’s Michelle O’Neill during a meeting, in Cardiff, on September 14. AP

back against the MoU. Emma Little-Pengelly, the Deputy First Minister, said the MoU was signed by Ms. O’Neill in her capacity as a leader of Sinn Féin and not as First Minister. It isn’t, she said, “on behalf of Northern Ireland”.

Scotland’s independence push

Many in Scotland, on the other hand, wish for it to become an independent country. Scotland voted for devolution in a 1997 referendum, and the Scottish Parliament was established in 1999. However, ever since the Scottish National Party (SNP) took power in the Holyrood (Scottish Parliament) in 2007, the demand for an absolute devolution of powers has been in the public discourse. The party had been consistently pushing for a referendum in Scotland on the question of independence, with one finally being held in 2014. While the referendum saw a massive turnout, the result was a major blow to the SNP; the Yes camp, which believed that Scotland should be independent, lost, receiving 44.7% of the votes. The No campaign won 55.3% of the total votes. While this led to a mild dampener for a period of time, the SNP, under Nicola Sturgeon, revived the demand again post-Brexit. She alleged that even though 62% of the Scottish people voted to remain in the European Union (EU), the U.K. left the alliance; this underlined the importance of self-determination for the Scottish people.

Currently, John Swinney, Prime Minister and leader of the SNP, upholds the same demand. While he advocated for the steady and gradual devolution of powers from Westminster when he first took the post of First Minister in 2024, the victory of pro-independence parties in the recent state elections, held in May 2026, has given Mr. Swinney and the SNP fresh hope. Together with the Scottish Green Party, the Holyrood now has 73 pro-independence members. Mr. Swinney has taken this to mean a shift in public opinion about the need for total devolution and has strongly pushed for mechanisms to hold a second referendum by 2031.

A shift in Wales

The strong stand taken by Wales in

signing the MoU is somewhat of a departure from its earlier position. The nation, a stronghold of the Labour Party for nearly a century, now has a non-Labour government led by Rhun ap Iorwerth, leader of Plaid Cymru. Plaid Cymru, established in 1925, has always held the ideal of self-determination at the centre of its political project. However, support for an independent Welsh nation has been a relatively minor position within the country as compared to Scotland. For example, the Welsh referendum in 1997, which was the first step to devolution of powers and the creation of a Welsh National Assembly, passed very narrowly with just 50.3% voting in favour of an Assembly as opposed to 49.7% who voted against the motion.

However, since then, the momentum for greater devolution from Westminster and more autonomy has been steadily gaining ground in the region. In the 2011 referendum, which was to decide whether the National Assembly for Wales should gain the power to legislate on a wider range of matters, the result was more promising with almost 63.49% voting yes for more powers as opposed to just 36.51% voting no.

The Labour Party, while being opposed to the idea of a total devolution of powers, has increasingly argued for more constitutional powers to Wales, especially regarding matters of policing and justice. In fact, in November 2021, the Labour-led Welsh government set up an Independent Commission on the Constitutional Future of Wales in order to seriously consider the possibility of an independent Wales along with other potential options such as enhanced devolution, and a more federal U.K. The Commission submitted its report in 2024 wherein it emphasised that the idea of an independent Wales cannot be kept out of popular imagination anymore even though it still does not enjoy as much as popular support as it does in Scotland. The report also underlined the possible “short-term to medium” risks especially with respect to currency, government finances, trade and movement across borders.

Therefore, Mr. Iorwerth’s positioning, even while signing the MoU at Cardiff with

Scotland and Northern Ireland, has been much more mellow than the other two regions. He has ruled out pushing for a referendum in his current term but has insisted that the possibility should be kept open; he stated that the people of Wales should have the option “to decide its own future”.

Response from Westminster

The U.K. Prime Minister Andy Burnham came to power riding on the agenda of more devolution of powers to local regions. He is a strong supporter of decentralisation; of giving more power to local governments and communities. In fact, in order to decentralise and shift power from central London, he has established a northern branch of 10, Downing Street in Manchester.

However, when Mr. Burnham visited Northern Ireland in August, he categorically stated that a border poll (referendum) on Irish unity was “off the table”. He said that his focus was to fix immediate crises such as the cost-of-living pressure and problems with public services. The reactions to his comments were sharp with nationalist parties taking it as a denouncement of the Good Friday Agreement. Sinn Féin’s president Mary Lou McDonald, who was the fourth signatory to the MoU, had stated that “We have the right to a referendum. We have the right to decide our future.... We will not accept or tolerate any Prime Minister telling us that right is off the table.”

The response to Scottish calls for a referendum have also been pretty much the same. When Mr. Swinney had written to Mr. Burnham, and asked if a mechanism for a referendum could be enshrined in law, Mr. Burnham stated that a Scottish border poll is currently “off-limits”.

The EU demand

Another significant aspect of the MoU was the call to reintegrate with the EU. The statement reads, “Brexit has damaged our economies, and limited opportunities for our people. Europe is our common home, and we believe the future of our nations belongs in the European Union”.

During the Brexit vote in 2016, Scotland (62%) and Northern Ireland (55%) had voted to remain. In Wales, roughly 52% voted to leave the EU, although a large minority voted to remain. All three governing parties are now resolute in their stance that the Brexit vote has been a total political failure. Even though a Trade and Cooperation Agreement has been signed with the EU, these nations allege that “non-tariff barriers” such as extra and time consuming paper work add to import and export delays.

However, reintegration would not be easy. Even if all three nations were to leave the U.K., reintegrating into the EU is a long process which could take years. For example, Montenegro has been in accession negotiations since 2012, and Serbia since 2014.

The Cardiff MoU is not a legal or multi-lateral treaty; it is a significant political statement by the governing parties of three regions, with varied histories, to put pressure on U.K.’s asymmetric federal model. Westminster’s constant refrain of ‘there are more important things to worry about’ gives these nations the idea that autonomy and devolution of powers is not seen as important enough by the U.K. Parliament. For a Prime Minister who has made decentralisation his central campaign, Mr. Burnham would be wise to pay more heed to the nations’ aspirations.

THE GIST

▼ Northern Ireland’s push is centred on reunification with Ireland, while Scotland is seeking independence and Wales is advocating greater autonomy, with the three nations’ positions shaped by their distinct political histories

▼ In Scotland and Wales, recent political developments have strengthened demands for greater powers, with Scotland pushing for a second independence referendum and Wales keeping the possibility of independence open while favouring further devolution

▼ Westminster has rejected immediate calls for referendums on Scottish independence and Irish reunification, while the three nations’ governments have criticised Brexit and called for closer integration with the European Union

LOKNITI SURVEY



Satisfaction with police remains low among cybercrime victims

Cybercrime reporting has expanded, but 63% of victims remain dissatisfied with police handling, with satisfaction falling to 43% during investigations; women and rural victims face greater difficulties, including repeated visits and long waiting times

Krishangi Sinha

As India undergoes a rapid digital transformation, cybercrime has emerged as one of the country's fastest-growing public safety challenges. From online financial fraud and identity theft to investment scams and phishing attacks, millions of Indians now encounter crimes that often leave lasting financial and psychological consequences.

In response, governments have expanded cyber helplines, launched the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, and established specialised cyber police stations across States. Yet, despite these institutional efforts, the Status of Policing in India Report 2026 finds that nearly two in three cybercrime victims (63%) remain dissatisfied with how the police handle their complaints, with one in five reporting being very dissatisfied. The findings suggest that while access to reporting mechanisms has improved considerably, improvements in accessibility have not been matched by victims' experience of justice, making the gap between complaint registration and effective police action the weakest link in India's cyber policing system (Table 1).

The satisfaction index combines victims' experiences across four stages: the cyber helpline, online portal, complaint registration and police investigation.

Victims report the highest satisfaction at the first point of contact, with half of helpline users expressing satisfaction ("very and somewhat satisfied"). However, confidence steadily erodes as complaints move through the system, dropping to 47% for the online portal, 46% during complaint registration, and just 43% for police investigations. The

findings suggest that the greatest challenge lies not in reporting cybercrime, but in seeing complaints through to a satisfactory resolution (Table 2).

Victims lose confidence

But the experience is not uniform. Women appear to have significantly poorer experiences than men (Table 3). While levels of moderate dissatisfaction are identical for both genders (42%), the gap widens in the most severe category. More than one in four women (26%) say they are very dissatisfied, compared to less than one in five men (18%).

For many victims, the challenge of reporting cybercrime is not only procedural but also time-consuming. 34 per cent of those who visited a police station to complain to the police waited two to three hours, while another 14% spent more than four hours before receiving assistance. Only 29% were attended to within an hour (Table 4). The findings suggest that lengthy waiting times continue to shape citizens' experience of accessing police services. Even where reporting mechanisms exist, delays at the police station may discourage victims from pursuing complaints, particularly in cases involving financial loss or repeated follow-up.

Registering and pursuing a complaint rarely ends with a single visit, as highlighted in Table 5. While 31% of victims reported visiting the police station only once or twice, nearly one in four had to return five times or more (23%). Victims in rural areas reported double the incidence of five or more visits to the police station (38%) compared to those residing in urban areas (19%). Repeated visits involve lost work hours, travel expenses, and administrative uncertainty, highlighting the need for more efficient

The gaps in cyber policing

For cybercrime victims, the challenges can continue well beyond the first step of reporting a complaint

Table 1: Index of satisfaction with police's handling of cybercrime

Level of satisfaction	(%)
Very satisfied	17
Somewhat satisfied	20
Somewhat dissatisfied	42
Very dissatisfied	21

Note: The index was created from these questions posed to victims: police helpline number for cyber complaints, online police portal for cybercrime, complaint registration process at cyber police station and investigation of cybercrimes by the police.



Table 2: Satisfaction of the victims of cybercrimes with various police services

	Degree of satisfaction (victims)				
	Very satisfied	Somewhat satisfied	Somewhat dissatisfied	Very dissatisfied	Never used these services*
Police helpline number for cybercrime complaints	18	32	13	14	20
Online police portal for cybercrime	16	31	13	12	24
Complaint registration process at the cyber police station	16	30	14	12	23
Investigation of cybercrime by the police	17	26	13	17	22

*This was a silent option and was only coded if the respondent explicitly said that. Note: All figures are in percentages. The rest did not respond. The table includes responses only from the victims. Question asked: How satisfied were you with the following – very satisfied, somewhat satisfied, somewhat dissatisfied, or very dissatisfied?

Table 3: Satisfaction with police handling cybercrime by gender

Gender	Index of satisfaction with police handling cybercrime			
	Very satisfied	Somewhat satisfied	Somewhat dissatisfied	Very dissatisfied
Male	19	21	42	18
Female	15	17	42	26

Table 4: Wait time (hours) at the police station to get complaint registered

Hours	(%)
1 hour or less	29
2 to 3 hours	34
4 to 5 hours	11
More than 5 hours	4

Note: The rest did not respond. All figures are in percentages. The table includes responses only from the victims.

Table 5: Number of visits to the police station

Number of times	(%)
Once or twice	31
Three or four times	24
Five times or more	23

Note: The rest did not respond. All figures are in percentages. The table includes responses only from the victims.

Table 6: Overall ease of registering a police complaint about cybercrime

Ease	(%)
Very easy	26
Somewhat easy	31
Somewhat difficult	25
Very difficult	17

Note: The rest did not respond. All figures in percentages. The table includes responses only from the victims.

case management and better communication during investigations.

Table 6 shows that victims' experiences of registering a complaint are mixed. A modest majority (57%) describe the process as very or somewhat easy, but 42% find it somewhat or very difficult. Across gender, women respondents were more likely to rate the process easier than men (61% and 54%, respectively).

India's cyber policing architecture has expanded rapidly over the past decade, reflecting the growing recognition of digital crime as a major governance challenge. However, the experiences of cybercrime victims suggest that

institutional capacity is still uneven where it matters most: investigation, follow-up and victim support. The findings underline a broader lesson for policing reforms: strengthening public trust requires moving beyond easier reporting mechanisms towards a system that is responsive, transparent and capable of delivering timely justice.

Krishangi Sinha is a researcher at Lokniti-CSDS. Views expressed are personal. This analysis is based on data collected during a comprehensive study on The Status of Policing in India Report 2026 jointly conducted by Lokniti-CSDS & Common Cause.

THE DAILY QUIZ

A quiz on all things coffee on the occasion of International Coffee Day

V. V. Ramanan

QUESTION 1
Name the place from which Baba Budan is said to have brought coffee beans to India, and how has the place's name become part of coffee lore?

QUESTION 2
What is the biggest contribution of Melitta Bentz and Achille Gaggia to the modern world of coffee brewing?

QUESTION 3
After which event did drinking coffee acquire a particularly patriotic significance among some American colonists as an alternative to tea?

QUESTION 4
What is the common name for the

coffee species called 'Coffea canephora'?

QUESTION 5
Which famous brand was officially launched in 1938 to help surplus Brazilian coffee crops?

QUESTION 6
Which famous composer wrote a comic opera called 'Coffee Cantata' about a young woman whose father tries to come between her and her coffee?

QUESTION 7
What is the name given to a trained professional who prepares and serves espresso-based and other coffee drinks in a café or coffee shop?



Visual Question:
This expensive coffee consists of partially digested coffee cherries that have been eaten and defecated by which animal?

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz:

1. Since 2012, CERN has held 'observer status' at the X, but without having the right to vote. As a result, CERN has been able to contribute scientific and technical expertise, central to X's work. Name X. **Ans: UN General Assembly**

2. When he was working at CERN, the English scientist ____ invented the World Wide Web. **Ans: Tim Berners-Lee**

3. What did India's Department of Atomic Energy present to CERN in 2004? It was selected to commemorate the Indian government's association with the organisation. **Ans: Statue of Lord Nataraja**

4. Of the 12 founding members of CERN, 11 remain. Name the country that ceded its membership in 1961, mainly for financial reasons. **Ans: Yugoslavia**

5. CERN runs a distributed computing project called _____. Here, people can donate spare processing power on their personal computers over the internet. **Ans: LHC@home**

Visual: Name this instrument, which is the largest particle collider on the Large Hadron Collider at CERN. It is 46 m long, 25 m high and 25 m wide, and weighs around 7,000 tonnes. **Ans: ATLAS**

Early Birds: Prem Raj P. | Jharna Kamdar | Dodo Jayaditya | Sitaram Saharay | Tariqa Bali



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning of “wild card” in tennis? (S. Velayuthan, Madurai)

Last year Goran Ivanisevic entered the Wimbledon Championship as a wild card and went on to win the men's singles title. Although he failed to get through the qualifying rounds, the officials at Wimbledon, taking into consideration his past performance, allowed him to play. And what a dream run Goran had! The expression “wild card” refers to a player who is allowed to participate in a tournament although technically he/she isn't qualified; he/she does not have the necessary ATP points. Selectors/officials usually determine who will receive the wild card. In most Grand Slam events, wild cards are given to up-and-coming players from the country where the event is taking place. For example, during the U.S. Open, most of the wild cards are given to Americans, and during Wimbledon, to the British players. Officials can give a top-ranked player a wild card as well.

What is the meaning of “can't see the wood for the trees”? (Mita Paul, Visakhapatnam)

Sometimes when you concentrate on the minute details of a problem, you lose sight of the overall picture; in other words, you focus on the unimportant, rather than on the important things. You miss the big picture. And that's what the expression “can't see the wood for the trees” means. The Americans tend to say “can't see the forest for the trees”.

Can the word “bon voyage” be used with people who are travelling by train or car? (B. Vishwanatha Rao, Hyderabad)

Well, the expression “bon voyage” means have a good journey. So whether the journey is by car or train, it shouldn't make a difference. I am sure that in 50 years' time we will be saying “bon voyage” to people travelling to the moon (or wherever).

What is the meaning of “get hot under the collar”? (G. Nithya, Thanjavur)

When we get angry, usually our body temperature rises; our face and neck feel hot, our palms sweat, etc. And where is our neck? It's usually under the collar. To “get hot under the collar” means to get angry.

Which of the following is correct? Compare to or compare with? (Murthy, Ravulapalam)

Both are acceptable; there is a tendency these days to use the two interchangeably. Careful users of the language, however, make a distinction between the two. When you compare something “with” something, then what you are doing is looking for similarities and differences. If you compare yourself with Tendulkar, then you are trying to find out in what way you are similar to Tendulkar and, in what way you are different. You are not making a value judgement. You may come up with a list of similarities and differences – that you are three inches taller than Tendulkar, you haven't scored as many runs as the master batsman, etc. If, on the other hand, you compare yourself “to” Tendulkar, then you are placing yourself on the same level as the great batsman. You feel you are as good as Tendulkar. Remember the song sung by the “Artist Once Known as Prince”, “Nothing compares to you”? Published in The Hindu on February 19, 2002

Word of the day

Bellwether:
someone who assumes leadership of a movement or activity

Synonyms: leader, pioneer, trendsetter, forerunner

Usage: His performance is a bellwether of the team's overall form.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/bellwether

International Phonetic Alphabet: /belwəðər/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

Mamata bats for Rahul as PM, Kharge calls for unity

Prepared to contribute as mere worker with 'no ego', says former Bengal CM; Congress chief says INDIA bloc should first fight threats to democracy; Rahul calls alliance 'defenders of Constitution'

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

Former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee endorsed Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi as the face of the Opposition alliance, telling leaders at the INDIA bloc meeting on Wednesday that she would have no objection if Mr. Gandhi were to become the Prime Minister.

Her remarks, however, were promptly met with a note of caution from Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, who said the gathering was not meant to discuss leadership positions but to forge a united response to the challenges facing the country.

Sources said Ms. Banerjee repeatedly emphasised the need for all Opposition parties to work together and said she was prepared to contribute as a mere worker. Stressing that she had "no ego", she cited her outreach to Biju Janata Dal leader Naveen Patnaik and referred to her recent conversation with CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby, despite the Trinamool Congress and the Left having been longstanding political rivals in West Bengal.



In sync: Sonia Gandhi, Mamata Banerjee, other INDIA bloc leaders address the media in New Delhi on Wednesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Pointing towards Mr. Gandhi, Ms. Banerjee said: "If Rahul Gandhi becomes Prime Minister, I have no problem."

Mr. Kharge intervened soon after, saying the meeting's purpose was not to decide who would occupy the top post but to stand together to "save the country".

'Different atmosphere'
Leaders present at the meeting described the atmosphere as markedly different from the INDIA bloc's previous gathering on June 8. Wednesday's discussions were characterised by Congress's wil-

lingness to accommodate suggestions from all parties.

Ideas mooted by Mr. Baby for a collective representation to the President, by CPI(ML) general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya of taking the agitation on "vote chori" (vote theft) beyond Delhi and the main cities, and by Independent Rajya Sabha member Kapil Sibal of legally challenging the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Bill, 2023, were accepted.

Rashtriya Janata Dal

leader Tejashwi Yadav suggested that there is a growing need for the INDIA bloc to speak in one voice, for which it should have designated spokespersons.

The bloc agreed that a sub-committee should be formed to take day-to-day decisions.

'To work with humility'
Mr. Gandhi, who spoke towards the end of the deliberations, stressed the importance of collective action and cooperation among alliance partners. He said the Congress was prepared to work with "humility" alongside other parties and argued that the alliance had a historic responsibility to defend democratic institutions.

"History will remember this group which is sitting here today as the one that defended the Constitution of India," he said.

Addressing the joint press conference later, Mr. Gandhi returned to the same theme. "Collectively, we are the defenders of the Indian Constitution," he said, adding that the coming months would be politically significant and that the Opposition intended to intensify its campaign against the government.

CEC has 'lifelong blanket immunity' for helping PM Modi 'steal' polls: Rahul

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, on Wednesday alleged that Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar has lifelong immunity from court proceedings because he helped the Narendra Modi government indulge in "vote chori" (theft).

"Q. Why is CEC Gyanesh Kumar the only Indian with lifelong blanket legal immunity? A. Because PM Modi uses him to steal elections," Mr. Gandhi said on X, shortly after the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance discussed the possibility of challenging the law that gives immunity to the CEC and the other two Election Commissioners.

At the INDIA bloc meeting, former Law Minister Kapil Sibal suggested that the Opposition challenge the 2023 law that gives the CEC and the two Commissioners immunity from criminal and civil proceedings. Section 16 of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners Act, 2023, protects both the CEC and the Commissioners.

A court cannot entertain proceedings against



Mulling a movement: Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi after an INDIA bloc meeting in Delhi on Wednesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

them for an act done in the discharge of their duty.

While the INDIA bloc is now exploring ways to challenge the law, at Tuesday's Congress Working Committee (CWC) meeting, senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi argued that court appeals often delayed matters. If a legal challenge by the Opposition was not upheld by the higher courts, the issue would not only appear as a setback but also legitimise the law, Mr. Singhvi is said to have argued.

'Mobilise support'
Several CWC members discussed other ways of building resistance to the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. Mr. Singhvi argued that non-political actors could help mobilise public support, and cited the Cockroach Janta Party-led anti-paper leak protests

as an example. He said the protests were effective in mobilising people and had also forced Dharmendra Pradhan to resign as the Education Minister.

However, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra and Anand Sharma argued the Congress should take the lead, with other parties and movements joining it.

Another CWC member, Manish Tewari, said the Congress should mobilise every party workers and call them to Delhi to sit on an indefinite dharna, much like what the Punjab farmers did during their opposition to the three farm laws.

Several Congress leaders argued that the party now needed to move beyond courtroom technicalities and work with people who had lost their right to vote, turning the issue into a people's movement.

EC extends SIR dates for A.P. and Meghalaya

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

A full bench of the Election Commission (EC) convened on Wednesday, in what was the second such meeting in four days, and decided to extend the dates for publication of the final electoral rolls in Andhra Pradesh (A.P.) and Meghalaya, which are among the States where the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls is currently under way.

In the EC meeting, attended by Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, it was decided that the final voters' list of A.P. would be published on October 16 and that of Meghalaya on October 26. The dates had previously been October 3 for A.P. and October 7 for Meghalaya. The claims and objections period in A.P. has been extended until October 10.

According to sources, the Commission also took stock of the implementation of measures announced on September 26, which addressed concerns, including stopping physical hearings for voters who have been flagged under the unmapped or logical discrepancies categories.

Govt. causing an ecological disaster in country: Cong.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Referring to the ₹92,000-crore Great Nicobar Island project, Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Wednesday said the Narendra Modi government was "mindlessly going ahead with inflicting this ecological disaster on our country".

Reacting to a report in *The Hindu* about the Union government moving the Supreme Court for a stay on hearings in the Calcutta High Court challenging the clearances for the project, the former Environment Minister said he hoped that the top court would let the final hearings continue before the High Court, where petitions have alleged that provisions of the Forest Rights Act, 2006, were violated in obtaining consent for the project.

The Hindu reported on Wednesday that the Union government had filed a petition in the Supreme Court seeking a stay on further proceedings in the matter before the Calcutta High Court.

Mr. Ramesh said the petitions in the High Court represented a "faint glimmer of hope" even as "various approvals under environment and forest laws have been deeply flawed, and the impact assessment reports are of dubious value".

"The High Court had upheld the right of the petitioner, who has been a very senior official in the Union Ministry of Environment... and the Ministry of Tribal Affairs, to file her challenge. Her right to challenge had been questioned by the Modi government, but that had been rejected by the High Court. Now, the government is making the same argument in the Supreme Court, which hopefully will allow the High Court to proceed on the matter as scheduled," he said.

'Fragmented' INDIA bloc is spreading misinformation: BJP

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Wednesday hit out at the Congress and its allies, alleging that they were spreading misinformation and undermining democratic institutions. Defending voter-list verification, the BJP also took a jibe at the absence of some alliance partners from the meeting of the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance on the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise.

At a press conference, Union Minister and senior BJP leader Shivraj Singh Chouhan said the Congress had failed to introspect despite multiple defeats. "If they win, they hail democracy; if they lose, they condemn the Election Commission. This is their frustration over defeat," Mr. Chouhan said.

'Will not improve'
"The Congress has decided that it will not improve. Whether it is Congress president Mallikarjun Khargeji or Rahul Gandhiji, instead of apologising for their mistakes, they are spread-



Shivraj Singh Chouhan

ing confusion. They are lying and making fabricated allegations," he said.

Referring to the INDIA bloc meeting, he said, "Even before the meeting, the alliance fell apart." He raised questions over the absence of Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam president M.K. Stalin, and Aam Aadmi Party chief Arvind Kejriwal.

Mr. Chouhan alleged that the Opposition alliance had become badly fragmented, with its constituent parties going separate ways. "The truth is that the INDI Alliance is not ready to accept Rahul Gandhi as its leader... even the Congress itself does not have faith in him," the BJP leader said.

SIR made so many eligible electors lose vote for the first time, says former CEC

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

When Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi found that their objections were not heard, especially regarding the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, they should not have stopped with dissent notes, says former Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) O.P. Rawat. Instead, the two Commissioners should have ensured all decisions taken against their will were annulled at the next meeting of the three-member commission, he said. The third member of the Election Commission is Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

Slamming the way the SIR has been carried out, Mr. Rawat noted in an exclusive interview with *The Hindu* on Wednesday that this is the first time since Independence that so many eligible electors had lost their voting rights.

Mr. Sandhu and Mr. Joshi had formally objected to various aspects of the SIR, 14 times over a 10-



O.P. Rawat

month period. Their objections covered several EC decisions, including changes to Form 6, and the ECI-Net portal's added declaration asking new voters whether they or their parents or grandparents had appeared in the last SIR's electoral roll.

"They had the majority [in the EC]. In the very next meeting, when their first objections were not heard, they should have annulled all decisions taken against the will of majority. They should have taken the right decision, which would have prevailed. So obviously, but they did not take that route," he said. Mr. Rawat helmed the poll body be-

ween January 23, 2018 and December 1, 2018. He had been an Election Commissioner from 2015.

'No veto for CEC'
Describing the EC's functioning, Mr. Rawat said that commission meetings are usually held regularly. Mr. Rawat said that when the members are not on the same page, meetings help them understand each other's point of view and bring about an agreement. In the "one in a million" occasion where consensus cannot be reached, he said, there is the recourse of voting, where the majority opinion prevails. "The Chief Election Commissioner himself does not have any veto," he said.

On the SIR process in West Bengal, he said the damage had already been done before the election. "Ninety-three per cent of deleted voters whose appeals have been decided by tribunals were found eligible, and they missed exercising their voting right. That is something very serious for a democracy," he said.

Bengal SIR tribunal judge wants to quit over long commute

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

A judge presiding over a special intensive revision (SIR) tribunal in West Bengal has offered to resign, citing the long commute between his residence and his place of work.

Justice Indrajit Chatterjee (ret'd), formerly judge at the Calcutta High Court, who is presiding over the appellate tribunal in Murshidabad district, has written to the Chief Justice of Calcutta High Court Ravindra Vithalrao Ghuge, expressing his wish to discontinue with effect from November 2.

"The government is spending a lot on my vehi-

cle and pilot car. But I have to commute 70 to 80 km from my residence, which takes three to four hours every day. It is difficult to continue under such circumstances," Justice Chatterjee told *The Hindu*.

He heads the SIR tribunal number 11, Murshidabad district, where the names of about 4.55 lakh electors have been deleted from the electoral rolls due to "logical discrepancies".

About 27.1 lakh voters were removed from the State's electoral rolls due to "logical discrepancies" before the Assembly election was held earlier this year. Over 22 lakh voters have filed appeals challenging their exclusion.

ଓଡିଶା ଗ୍ରାମ୍ୟ ଉନ୍ନୟନ ଓ ବିକାଶ ସମିତି
ପଞ୍ଚାୟତିରାଜ ଓ ପାହାନ୍ତି କ୍ଷେତ୍ର ବିଭାଗ, ଓଡିଶା ସରକାର

Odisha Rural Development & Marketing Society
creating competence and values in rural Odisha
Panchayati Raj and DW Department, Government of Odisha

NOTICE

Expression of Interest for Empanelment of PIAs under Captive Employment Category "A" for DDU-GKY 2.0 Projects in Odisha State

No.2859 / PT1-ORMAS-SD-DDU-GKY-0007-2025 Date : 30.09.2026

Odisha Rural Development and Marketing Society (ORMAS), under the Panchayati Raj & Drinking Water Department, Government of Odisha, invites proposals from agencies registered with the Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD), Government of India and possessing a valid Permanent Registration Number (PRN), for empanelment and implementation of DDU-GKY 2.0 projects in the State of Odisha under "Captive Employment Category- A".

Interested agencies may submit their proposals through the DDU-GKY online portal of MoRD, Government of India (<https://kaushal.rural.gov.in>), in accordance with the DDU-GKY 2.0 Operational Guidelines, Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs), and other instructions issued by MoRD from time to time.

The last date for submission of proposals is **21st October 2026**. Detailed terms and conditions of the Expression of Interest (EOI) are available on the portal at <https://kaushal.rural.gov.in>

Chief Executive Officer, ORMAS

SIRD Campus, Unit- VIII, Bhubaneswar, Odisha - 751012
Tel# 0674-2565870/71, E-mail : ormasha@gmail.com, URL : www.ormas.org
19001/275/2627 OIPR-19001/19004/1/26-27/0011

Government of Odisha
Information & Public Relations Department
Lok Sampark Bhawan, Bhubaneswar

Request For Proposal (RFP) from the eligible bidders to Conceptualize, Design and Fabricate the Odisha Pavilion at India International Trade Fair (IITF)-2026, Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi.

BIDDER'S DATA SHEET

Sl.No.	Particular	Details
01.	Name of the Client	The Director, I&PR Department, Odisha
02.	Method of Selection	Quality and Cost Based Selection (QCBS) Method
03.	Date of the Issue of RFP	30.09.2026
04.	Pre-Bid Consultation with intending bidders	06.10.2026 at 11:30 AM
05.	Venue of Pre-Bid Consultation	Conference Hall, Lok-Sampark Bhawan, Unit-V, Keshari Nagar, Bhubaneswar-751001
06.	RFP Due Date	14.10.2026 by 05.00 PM
07.	Date & Time of Opening of the Proposal	15.10.2026 at 11:30 AM
08.	Venue of Opening of Proposal	Conference Hall, Lok-Sampark Bhawan, Unit-V, Keshari Nagar, Bhubaneswar-751001
09.	Address for Submission of Proposal	The Director, I&PR Department, Odisha Lok-Sampark Bhawan, Unit-V, Keshari Nagar, Bhubaneswar-751001 (Odisha), Telephone No-2394890, Email: fpiprodisha@gmail.com
10.	Mode of Submission	➤ Speed Post/Registered Post/Courier Service only ➤ Proposals submitted in any other mode and the ones received late will not be taken into consideration

DIRECTOR, I&PR
OIPR-15001/15001/11/26-27/0101

SOUTHERN POWER DISTRIBUTION COMPANY OF TELANGANA LIMITED

e-Procurement Tender Notice (Paper Notification)

TSPPDCL intends to float tender for procurement of (a) Desktop Computers (b) 8.1 m/280 kgs PSCC Poles to various circles of TSPPDCL (c) 11 m/385 kgs PSCC Poles to various circles (d) 11 KV 200A (TT) GOAB Switches with Polymer Insulators (e) LT Distribution Boxes (SMC) of TSPPDCL on e-procurement platform.

For further details of each item above, please visit www.tgssouthernpower.org, www.tender.telangana.gov.in, www.auction.telangana.gov.in.
Phone : 040-23431360, 1033, 1035, 1026.

R.O. No.: 594-PPCL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt: 30.09.2026

CHIEF ENGINEER (P&MM)
TSPPDCL, Hyderabad

ଓଡିଶା ବିଦ୍ୟୁତ୍ ଚକ୍ତି ସଂଚାରଣ ନିଗମ ଲିମିଟେଡ୍
(ଓଡିଶା ସରକାରଙ୍କ ଏକ ଉପକ୍ରମ)
Regd. Office: OPTCL Tech Tower, Janpath, Saheed Nagar, Bhubaneswar-751007

ODISHA POWER TRANSMISSION CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of Odisha Undertaking)

E-TCN NO.-CPC-85/2026-27: OPTCL invites bids under single stage two part system from any bidder for Engineering, Supply, Erection, Testing and Commissioning of High Temperature Low Sag(HTLS) conductor after dismantling of ACSR Panther Conductor in existing 132kV Burla PH-Katapali Ckt-I&II line in Sambalpur District on Turnkey Contract Basis in e-tendering mode only. The estimated cost of the tender is **Rs. 12,41,57,478/-**. The last date & time of Submission of Bid Dt. 27.10.2026 up to 12:45 P.M.

E-TCN NO.- TW-IT/OT/01/2026-27: Bids invited in e-tender mode from reputed bidders for Selection of vendor towards development of Geo-Fencing enabled iOS based mobile application in line with already developed android based OLAMP mobile application. Security audit and subsequent Annual Maintenance Contract (AMC) Support for three years. The estimated cost of the tender is **Rs. 24,42,600/-**. The bid shall be due on date 22.10.2026 13:30 Hrs.

For details, visit OPTCL's official website <http://www.optcl.co.in> and www.tenderwizard.com/OPTCL. HPR-63/2026-27

📞📧/optcl.odisha 📧/optcl_odisha

INBRIEF



PDP submits privilege motion against Chief Secy., Law Secy.

The Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) on Wednesday proposed to move a Motion of Privilege against Chief Secretary Atal Dulloo and Law Secretary Achal Sethi for their “role and conduct” and “questioning” the Chief Minister Omar Abdullah’s Statehood resolution passed on Monday. “In view of the concerns placed on record by the Chief Minister regarding the role and conduct of the two senior officers in questioning the contents and language of a resolution of this House, I intend to move a Motion of Privilege....” said PDP MLA Waheed-ur-Rehman Para, in a letter addressed to the Speaker Abdul Rahim Rather.

Govt. to re-employ Dharendra Ojha as Principal DG at PIB

The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) has approved the re-employment of senior Indian Information Service official Dharendra Ojha as Principal Director General, Press Information Bureau (PIB), on a contract basis for a period of one year beyond his superannuation on Wednesday. The order will be effective from October 1, 2026, to September 30, 2027, or until further orders, whichever is earlier, on the usual terms and conditions applicable to re-employed Central government officers, keeping the recruitment rules in abeyance.

SC rules out total ban on firecrackers for Deepavali

Court sees worth in CSIR-NEERI report on new-generation joined green crackers with lower noise, particulate emissions, and solid waste generation; Bench mulls specific time windows for bursting

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Ruling out a nationwide ban on firecrackers, the Supreme Court on Wednesday accepted suggestions by the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research-National Environmental Engineering Research Institute (CSIR-NEERI) for a “limited and conditional relaxation”.

The court backed the premier scientific body’s recommendations for manufacture of next-generation joined green crackers in compliance with applicable noise, emission, and safety requirements ahead of Deepavali festivities.

Appearing before a Bench headed by Justice M.M. Sundresh, Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati, for the Centre, said CSIR-NEERI has recommended that green crackers conform to specifications/formulations tested and approved by the competent authority and are made exclusively by duly-licensed manufacturers.



The court says it will take a balanced view, particularly over anxiety of air pollution with the onset of winter. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

CSIR-NEERI has suggested that crackers must be within the prescribed noise limit of 125 dB (A)/145 dB(C) peak and strictly fall within permissible emission brackets, Ms. Bhati said.

The law officer submitted that CSIR-NEERI has prescribed the shell size, shell number and bursting duration/time of green crackers, which showed less noise and emissions than conventional joined crackers. The scientific report underscored that these crackers should be free of banned chemical ingredients.

The CSIR-NEERI report

on the “new-generation joined firecrackers” said a series of the green variety had been developed without the use of barium in their compositions. These crackers were different from the conventional ones in terms of shell/tube size, formulation, bursting duration, and frequency of bursting, with corresponding reductions in noise, particulate emissions and solid waste generation, the report said.

30% reduction

Tests conducted on them show a 30% reduction in emissions compared to conventional joined crack-

ers. The shrinking of the shell size has also reduced solid waste generation from 4% up to 32%, the report said.

“The bursting time duration has increased five times in the next-generation joined green crackers,” the report noted.

The court said it would take a balanced view on the issue of firecrackers, particularly with apprehensions of air pollution with the onset of winter and the festive season.

“Total ban will hurt certain sentiments. We will not agree on a total ban across the country. At the same time, we will not allow a 24-hour bursting anywhere, as it affects the sick, the elderly, and children,” the Bench remarked orally.

The court said it would look into directing specific time windows for bursting crackers.

The court gave more time to the Central Pollution Control Board and the Union government to continue with further barium and joined firecracker tests to test decibel levels.

Stricter laws against online pornography needed, say activists

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Social activists and advocates on Wednesday called for stronger legal safeguards against unrestricted access to pornographic and sexually explicit content online, particularly for children and adolescents, in the wake of a series of cases of rape lately, and in the more recent instance the gang-rape of a minor near a Delhi college.

The issue was not merely about regulating digital content but about the safety of women and children, prevention of sexual violence, and the social environment in which India’s younger generation is growing up, former Central Information Commissioner Uday Mahurkar said at a press conference.

The press conference was also addressed by Yogita Bhayana, founder of People Against Rape in India; Vishnu Shankar Jain, advocate-on-record in the Supreme Court; Sanjeev Newar, founder of Sewa Nyay Utthan and Rashtra Jyoti; Vineet Jindal, advocate and social activist; and Amita Sachdev, Supreme Court advocate.

The government’s action against 25 OTT platforms carrying obscene content in 2025 was a step in the right direction, Mr. Mahurkar said, but called for stringent laws. His memorandum to Prime Minister Narendra Modi sought a dedicated law to prevent persons below 18 from accessing pornographic and obscene content, robust age verification, and greater platform accountability.

A blanket ban on minors using social media could be considered, as done in Australia, he said, adding that laws prohibiting minors from accessing pornographic content were in place in 16 countries. The memorandum suggested amendments to the Indecent Representation of Women (Prohibition) Act, 1986, and proposed 10 years’ imprisonment, no bail for three years, and attachment of properties of convicted offenders.

Prevention must begin before a crime is committed by protecting children from influences that can distort their understanding of sex, consent, and human relationships, Ms. Bhayana said.

On the draw



Punjab Congress chief offers to quit

Press Trust of India
CHANDIGARH

Punjab Congress president Amarinder Singh Raja Warring has offered to resign from his post following weeks of infighting in the

State unit, party sources said on Wednesday.

Former Minister and MP Vijay Inder Singla has emerged as the front-runner for the post ahead of the 2027 Assembly polls, they said. The Congress

high command has informed Mr. Warring of its decision to replace him, following which he has offered to resign, the sources said. The announcement of a new Punjab Congress chief is expected soon.

NCERT textbook revives debatable theory on Sengol handed to Nehru at Independence

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

The Union government’s claim that a *Sengol*, which is a sceptre anointed by Hindu religious leaders, marked the transfer of power in 1947 when India became Independent, finds a mention in the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT)’s newly released Class 9 social science textbook.

The new textbook, *Understanding Society: India and Beyond - Part Two*, says, “The *Sengol*, a cultural marker of rulership and good governance, was placed in India’s newly inaugurated Parliament building in 2023 by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The tradition of using the *Sengol* as a mark of righteous governance began more than a thousand years ago during the reign of Chola dynasty,” the textbook reads.

“To mark the occasion of India’s Independence, at the stroke of midnight on 15 August 1947, the first Prime Minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, received the *Sengol* from the Adheenam saints (an old Shaivite tradition) of Tamil Nadu,” it says.

Ethical responsibilities

Describing the *Sengol*, the website of the Union Culture Ministry says, “Once integral to the coronation rites of Tamil monarchs, the *Sengol* was not merely a ceremonial object but a profound testament to the ethical responsibilities bestowed upon a ruler. This sacred tradition was momentarily revived on the eve of India’s independence in 1947, when a *Sengol* was solemnly presented to Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru. It marked the ‘civilisationally rooted’ transfer of authority from colonial rule to a sovereign Indian state.”

This theory has been



The *Sengol*, a sceptre from Tamil Nadu, that was installed in the new Parliament building in May 2023. FILE PHOTO

contradicted time and again by experts. For instance, historian and biographer of C. Rajagopalachari, Rajmohan Gandhi has earlier said in public domain during the inauguration of the new Parliament building that there is no record of the *Sengol* serving as a formal symbol of the “transfer of power”, in the personal papers, letters or autobiographies of either Nehru or Rajaji.

Historian Aditya Muk-

herjee had also criticised the 2023 ceremony and the installation of the *Sengol*, stating that the event was an effort of political self-glorification rather than celebrating parliamentary democracy.

The textbook says India’s national motto – *Satyameva Jayate* – is linked to Mundaka Upanishad replacing the British-era “Heaven’s Light, Our Guide”. The textbook says the Supreme Court’s post-Independence motto *Yato Dharmastato Jayah*, which translates into “Where there is righteous duty, there is victory”, is linked to the Mahabharata. This is stated in the chapter “Governance and Public Policy” of the new textbook.

The chapter links Mahatma Gandhi’s reference to *Ram Rajya*, which is an ideal governance structure based on probity, transparency, compassion, and welfare, to the Ramayana and the 16th century liter-

ary work *Ramcharitmanas*, calling these two texts “examples of good governance and good collective life”.

‘Sacred responsibility’

The textbook says that from the Vedic period to the Ramayana and Mahabharata, Indian traditions viewed governance as a “sacred responsibility” rather than merely a means of exercising power.

The chapter says that colonial powers imposed their models of governance on societies which had previously followed “local and organic systems”, and that many colonial institutions have continued since Independence.

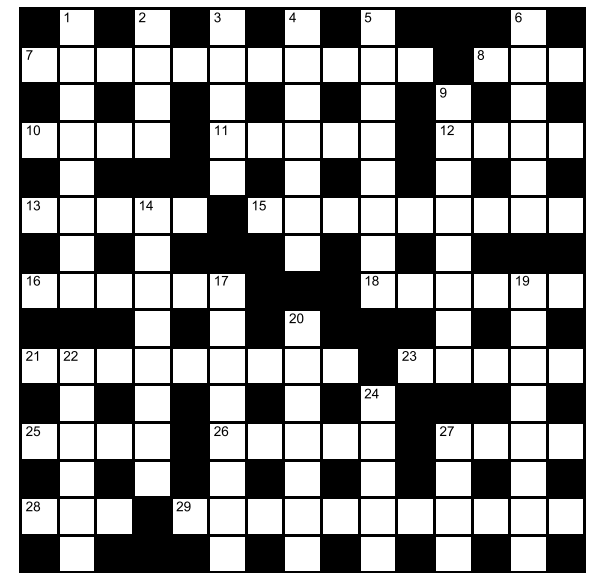
In another chapter titled “Resistance and Resilience”, the textbook says many kings and princes are believed to have received swords from goddesses such as Kali, Durga and Bhavani to resist invasions since the 7th century.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14912

(set by Hypatia)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

- 7 Fan boy dancing around extremely brave girl in main area (3,2,6)
- 8 Cool stuff kept in kitchen, frequently (3)
- 10 Breakfast food includes deliciously light item for starters (4)
- 11 Place with bars in state wasting bachelor's time? (5)
- 12 Right from list in podcast (4)
- 13 In France, good backing the aristocrat (5)

- 15 British actors terribly bored by promotion in show (9)
- 16 Model on magazine / paper (6)
- 18 Daughter first abandoned strays (6)
- 21 Doctor to those having power — a therapist (9)
- 23 Categories of nasty pests (5)
- 25 Mammals oddly avoided a plant (4)
- 26 Fleece customers at the end, after independent portraits (5)
- 27 Daily plan's incomplete (4)
- 28 Snake vanishing with insect (3)
- 29 Peril of an important position (4,7)

Down

- 1 Style of cooking indoor at spreads (8)
- 2 Drive near huge unending desert (4)
- 3 Boat capsizing every now and then had to sink (5)
- 4 Secures Emcees (7)
- 5 Spooner's simple palm accessory (8)
- 6 Entrance of conservative church blocked behind (6)
- 9 Enthusiasm of star ultimately settling in American Hollywood's home (8)
- 14 Criminal saves gal in Sin City (3,5)
- 17 Obscene clip shot in retreat (8)
- 19 Tips from Spooner to understand stories (8)
- 20 Decline an award (7)
- 22 Almost identical like old inverted triangular snack (6)
- 24 Unlawfully seize using reprobate political leaders! (5)
- 27 Outlet that serves public a few sandwiches (4)

SUDOKU

8				1		5		
				3	8	5		9
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	8			2	5	9		1
	9			8	6	1		5
7	2							
	5			6	3	2		
		6		9				8

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle	Solution to yesterday's Sudoku
G I T I E F E T R N D A P F T B E N D O R S E N A B O B W E T I N A T I W T B E O D T H A I R S B I A L S S V T R A L N S L S G O R A A B E T T O S N T R T H E T M A N	6 8 3 9 2 1 7 5 4 5 7 2 4 3 6 8 9 1 9 4 1 5 8 7 2 3 6 8 1 5 6 9 4 3 2 7 3 6 9 2 7 8 4 1 5 7 2 4 1 5 3 9 6 8 1 3 6 7 4 2 5 8 9 4 5 8 3 1 9 6 7 2 2 9 7 8 6 5 1 4 3

FAITH

Mighty Garuda

Garuda flew to devaloka at great speed to get the pot of nectar, which Indra was guarding. Garuda had to give the nectar to Kadru to free his mother from her. Indra was terrified by Garuda’s speed. He asked all the devas to use their might against Garuda. But they were powerless against Garuda. Indra himself began to fight Garuda. Finally, Indra threw the vajrayudha at him. The vajrayudha had been fashioned with the bone of sage Dadichi. But even the vajrayudha could not harm Garuda, said Then-thiruperaai Aravindalochanan in a discourse. However, Garuda did not want to disrespect a weapon made with a sage’s bone. So, he dropped a feather, which was beautiful and glowed like gold. He thus came to be known as Suparna – the one with a lovely feather.

Garuda is an auspicious bird. It is said that if you see a jackal, it is a good sign, but if you hear it howling, it is a bad omen. But in the case of Garuda, it is auspicious to see him and to hear him. Undeterred by Indra’s weapons, Garuda proceeded towards the nectar. Above the pot was a circle of fire. But Garuda was able to take the pot. Indra appealed to Vishnu for help, for if Kadru’s children, who were snakes, consumed nectar, they would be immortal. It would be a danger to everyone if venomous snakes were immortal. Vishnu confronted Garuda and after fighting him, He offered him two boons. But Garuda offered the Lord two boons. Garuda became the Lord’s mount and His flag. The Lord also told him how he could give the nectar to Kadru, but prevent the snakes from eating it. Thus, Garuda saved his mother, without making the snakes immortal.

PARIS
Eiffel Tower chief to step down after controversy during BAPS visit



Patrick Branco Ruivo, the head of the company that runs the Eiffel Tower, will step down at the end of the year after female staff at the landmark building in Paris were excluded during a visit by a Hindu religious group, BAPS. The decision is after a probe uncovered a series of operational failures in relation to the September 5 visit. AP

BRUSSELS
Russia sends nuclear warning to NATO as tensions rise in the Baltic



Russia has warned NATO it would be ready to resort to nuclear weapons if the Western alliance attempted to cut off Kaliningrad, a Russian exclave that borders the Baltic Sea. In a document sent to NATO, Moscow accused the alliance of a “dangerous course” that entailed “high risks of outbreak of a direct armed conflict”. REUTERS

KABUL
Afghanistan claims its forces killed 41 insurgents crossing from Pak.



Afghanistan's Defence Ministry says its forces have killed more than 40 fighters it described as insurgents who crossed into the country from neighbouring Pakistan, and captured dozens more over three days amid repeated clashes along the tense border. The insurgents included members of the Islamic State group, it said. AP

WASHINGTON
U.S. to hike EB-5 Green Card fees; charges to take effect on Nov. 30



The U.S. has decided to increase fees for immigrants seeking to invest in America and eventually claim permanent residency (Green Card) under the EB-5 investor programme, with new charges taking effect on November 30. The filing fee for Form I-526, used by standalone investors, will rise from \$3,675 to \$7,615. PTI

Iran says it has received an official U.S. response to its offer to end war

Iranian officials have not disclosed whether Washington accepted or rejected the proposal; Araghchi briefs Pezeshkian and the Cabinet, with Iranian President calling for a ‘win-win strategy’; Trump earlier rejected the offer, calling it ‘unacceptable’

Associated Press
DUBAI

Iranian officials indicated on Wednesday they have received an official U.S. response to Tehran's latest proposal to end the seven-month war, which U.S. President Donald Trump had publicly rejected just days earlier.

The officials did not say what the response contained, and whether it was a rejection or not.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi presented the U.S. response to President Masoud Pezeshkian at a Cabinet meeting, government spokesperson Fatemeh Mohajerani told the



Abbas Araghchi speaks to the media during the 81st session of the UN General Assembly at United Nations headquarters. AP

state-run IRNA news agency. “We will make every effort to bring the agreement to fruition and will firmly stand up for the rights of the Iranian people,” Mr.

Pezeshkian said. “The agreement must now be based on a win-win strategy.”

The Cabinet meeting follows Mr. Araghchi's return

to Iran after travelling to New York for the UN General Assembly last week. While there, officials held indirect talks with U.S. officials and also met with Qatari and Pakistani mediators on the sidelines of the annual gathering of world leaders.

Mr. Araghchi briefed the Cabinet on his trip to New York and the meetings he held there, including Iran's conditions for reopening the Strait of Hormuz, which Ms. Mohajerani said had been conveyed through mediators.

Mr. Araghchi last week said he floated the proposal to reopen the strait in a week if the U.S. agreed to

lift its blockade of Iranian ports, release frozen Iranian assets and waive sanctions on Iranian oil sales, among other conditions.

Mr. Trump swiftly rejected the proposal, saying Iran wanted to make a deal because it was “losing so badly” but that its offer “would not be acceptable”.

Meanwhile, the U.S. Treasury Department, as part of “Operation Economic Outcast” campaign, unveiled new sanctions on Tuesday targeting people and companies around the globe that it accuses of being financial facilitators or enablers of Iran's military supply chain.

Full re-entry into EU is an option for U.K.: Burnham

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

The U.K. rejoining the European Union (EU) was an option for the country, British Prime Minister Andy Burnham said on Wednesday, a day after he told the Labour party conference in Liverpool that the country had to decide on the kind of long-term ties it wanted with the bloc.

The Prime Minister had said that Brexit had “caused more harm than good” yesterday in Liverpool. The question of reversing Brexit, Britain's departure from the bloc in 2016, would likely be a deeply divisive process as Brexit itself was.

“We could stay as we are...if people think this is the right place to stay,” Mr. Burnham told BBC Radio



Andy Burnham

4's Today programme on Wednesday.

Other options would include looking at a customs union as suggested by former Conservative Chancellor George Osborne, or entering the Single Market (area for free movement of goods, services, people and capital) as suggested by the Liberal Democrats, Mr. Burnham said.

“...Or we could go all the way,” he said, suggesting

the U.K. could become part of the EU again.

The options would have to be weighed as per their pros and cons, Mr. Burnham said.

Prior to becoming Prime Minister, Mr. Burnham had said he was not looking to take the country back into the bloc but had said he hoped the return to the EU would happen during his lifetime.

Under his predecessor Keir Starmer's administration, the U.K. was in the process of strengthening ties with the EU, its largest trading partner. The Starmer government had launched a new ‘U.K.-EU Strategic Partnership’ which sought greater collaboration on defence, security, youth mobility and agriculture among other sectors.

23 years after invasion, U.S. troops pull out of Iraq; Iran's influence stays

NEWS ANALYSIS

Stanley Johnny

On May 1, 2003, nearly two months after launching the invasion of Iraq, the then U.S. President George W. Bush landed on the deck of the aircraft carrier USS Abraham Lincoln, which was off the San Diego coast after returning from combat operations in the Persian Gulf.

Arriving in a Lockheed S-3 Viking and dressed in a flight suit, Mr. Bush posed for photographs with pilots and crew members. A few hours later, he announced the end of major combat operations in Iraq. “In this battle, we have fought for the cause of liberty and for the peace of the world. Our nation and our coalition are proud of this accomplishment, yet it is you, the members of the United States military, who achieved it,” Mr. Bush said from the flight deck of the carrier. Above him hung the warship's now-famous banner: “Mission Accomplished”.

Except that it wasn't. On September 30, more than 23 years after Mr. Bush gave his “mission accomplished” speech, the U.S. forces withdrew from their last military base in Iraq, wrapping up their combat operations and leaving the country in the hands of a divided government and powerful Iran-backed Shia militias. Iran, which is currently at war with the U.S., and the militias have welcomed the U.S. withdrawal as a victory.

Stuck in Iraq
The U.S. invaded Iraq saying Saddam Hussein's regime had possessed weapons



Members of the Iraqi security forces drive in a convoy as they celebrate the U.S. withdrawal, in Najaf, Iraq, on Wednesday. REUTERS

of mass destruction and harboured al-Qaeda terrorists. The invasion was the second stop in Mr. Bush's ‘war on terrorism’.

Before launching the attack, Mr. Bush had grouped Iraq, Iran, and North Korea together as the ‘Axis of Evil’, indicating that Iran could be the next target. The claim about weapons of mass destruction turned out to be false. Al-Qaeda gained a foothold in Iraq only after the U.S. invasion toppled the Saddam Hussein regime.

Al-Qaeda in Iraq (AQI), one of the most violent branches of the terrorist organisation, later transformed into the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS) and spread terror across the region and beyond. Iraq also fell into a deadly sectarian civil war between Shias and Sunnis.

Perhaps the most consequential effect of the invasion was the expansion of Iranian influence across Iraq. Saddam's Iraq, which had fought an eight-year-long war with Iran, had remained a buffer between the Islamic Republic and Gulf monarchies.

Once Saddam was gone, Iran, which had built historical ties with Iraq's Shia parties that had been suppressed by the Baathist re-

gime, extended and deepened its reach. It also supported Shia militias with money, weapons and training to trap U.S. forces, as Tehran feared that the U.S. could turn against Iran next if it managed to stabilise Iraq.

Forever war
Over the past 23 years, the U.S. had spent some \$1.7 trillion and lost 4,500 troops in Iraq. Hundreds of thousands of Iraqis were also killed during the war.

In 2011, the then President Barack Obama had announced an end to U.S. combat operations in Iraq. But after the Islamic State captured huge swathes of territory in Iraq, including Mosul, the second largest city, U.S. troops returned to fight IS terrorists.

Since then the U.S. had retained some 2,500 troops, mostly in its bases in Erbil, in Iraqi Kurdistan. All these troops are now being withdrawn. Some marines will remain in the country to protect U.S. diplomatic missions.

President Trump says Iraq can now take care of its own security and hence the U.S. troops are no longer needed. But the ground situation is a lot more complex.

U.S. troops came under

increasing attack from Iran-backed Shia militias in recent years. The militias are powerful political and military entities today. Even though the Iraqi government has pushed them to disarm, it has faced severe resistance.

After the U.S. war on Iran began on February 28, the militias, loosely called Popular Mobilisation Units (Hashad al-Shabi), have stepped up their attacks on U.S. forces.

In the first two months of the war, Iran and the Shia militias launched more than 600 attacks on U.S. military and diplomatic facilities in Iraq. The U.S. found it increasingly difficult to keep a large group of troops in a region that's turning hostile, and Mr. Trump decided to stick to the Biden-era deadline of completing the withdrawal by September 30.

Shifting balance
Even though Iran built deep influence in Iraq through Shia political parties and militias after the American invasion, the presence of U.S. troops and an autonomous Kurdistan closely aligned with Washington provided a counterweight, maintaining a balance between the two rival centres of power.

With the U.S. troops leaving, that balance could tilt further in Iran's favour.

When U.S. air strikes killed Abu Mahdi al-Muhandis, the commander of Hashad, along with Qassem Soleimani, in January 2020, many saw it as a major blow to Iraq's Shia militias. Six years later, as U.S. troops leave the last of their bases in Iraq, Hashad appears to be more deeply entrenched than ever. So is Iran.

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REALLY SPECIAL

Sahil thrilled at making the grade for the Los Angeles Olympics



R.V. MOORTHY

It's a big thing for me to win an Asian Games gold and get an Olympic quota for the country. That is what every athlete dreams of... going to the Olympics, representing your country, winning medals. To do so here in my first Asian Games feels really special — Sahil Jadhav, who won the mixed and men's team gold medals.

IDEAL FOIL

Kynan kept pushing me to deliver my best, says Neeru



PTI

Indian shooter Neeru Dhandha credited Kynan Chenai and her team for keeping her motivated enough to shoot a decent score in the trap mixed team event. "All through the qualifying and final, Kynan kept encouraging me, pushing me to do my best even when I struggled to score. It helped a lot".

ON THE BALL

Pranavi second among women as the Indian golfers begin well



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Pranavi Urs fired a four-under 66 to lie second in the individual standings while the Indian women were tied sixth after the first round at the Asian Games. With the two best scores counting towards the team competition, India posted a score of three-under. Among men, Saptak Talwar shot a four-under 66 to lie tied third.

EASY OUTING

Indian squash teams advance to the semifinals, assured of medals



X@INDIASQUASH

The Indian men's and women's squash teams eased into the Asian Games semifinals with wins over Kuwait and Singapore respectively, assuring themselves of a medal in Nagoya on Wednesday. **The results: Quarterfinals: Men:** India 2 bt Kuwait 0. **Women:** India 2 bt Singapore 0 .

Indian archers hit the bullseye with three gold medals

The exploits of the men's, women's and mixed compound teams lift the pall of gloom that had enveloped the contingent after an underwhelming campaign so far; the overall tally rises to 60

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

For two weeks, the Indian contingent had flattered to deceive, falling short of expectations and medals. All this while, the archers had remained in the shadows, focussed on the big picture.

That picture burst into a 1000 colours on a bright, sunny Wednesday morning in Aichi-Nagoya as the compound archers retained three of the five gold medals from the last edition — the men's, women's and mixed team — along with a quota for the Los Angeles Olympics. The individual matches are scheduled for Thursday.

India's golden haul coincided with the sky clearing up over the city after four days of non-stop rains and overcast conditions, much like the gloom in the Indian contingent so far over a lack of medals.

The Okazaki Chuo Sogo



Triple treat: The women's trio of Prithika, Chikitha and Jyothi, mixed duo of Sahil and Chikitha and men's team of Kushal, Sahil and Ganesh struck the yellow metal. R.V. MOORTHY

Park Multipurpose Square was rife with excitement as the Indian trio of Jyothi Surekha, Chikitha Taniparthi and Prithika Pradeep walked out for their semifinal against powerhouse Korea, knowing well this would be a much sterner test than perhaps even the final.

Both teams started cautiously with a 59 each in the opening round. Things turned from the second,

when India got another 59 while Yerin Park struck two nines and Jungyoon Park and Yeonsoo Kang got one each for a round of 56 and a three-point lead to India.

Korea looked like fighting back with a perfect 60 in the third round to India's 58 but the one-point advantage carried over into the decider.

Prithika had just one nine, on her first arrow, fol-

lowed by all perfect targets thereafter. Jyothi needed a nine or better on the final shot and she managed exactly that to win 234-233.

India was always in control in the final against China, starting with a perfect 60 to take a two-point lead after the first round and extending it with a 59 to 58 in the second.

China reduced the margin by one in the third and managed a 58 in the final

round which left India needing only a combined total of 57 or more to win; they did better with a perfect 60 to win 238-234, equalling the world, Asian and Games records in the process.

Chikitha then combined with Sahil Jadhav to win the mixed team event in a shoot-off against Korea after the two were tied on 157 at the end of regulation shots.

India started with perfect 40s in the first two rounds while Jungyoon Park and Yonghee Choi both missed one shot apiece in each round for two 39s.

Korea clawed back over the next two rounds but Chikitha kept her nerves in the shoot-off.

The day's final gold came when Sahil combined with Ganesh Thirumuru and Kushal Dalal to

first demolish the Koreans in the semifinals 236-229 and then overturned a two-point deficit against China in the final to win 238-237.

China started strongly, taking a two-point lead after the first round with a 60 and nines from Kushal and Ganesh. India pulled one back in Round 3 when Jinyi Liu's nine on the 14th arrow hurt China. India won 238-237.

Medals table

	Country	G	S	B	T
1	China	151	67	59	277
2	Japan	50	77	73	200
3	South Korea	24	30	49	103
4	Uzbekistan	16	19	19	54
5	Thailand	12	10	12	34
8	India	10	21	29	60

Neeru-Kynan duo claims the trap mixed team gold



A moment to savour: Neeru, right, and Kynan celebrate their triumph. PTI

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

On Tuesday, Neeru Dhandha fought her opponents and the elements to win India's first and only individual gold so far in shooting. On Wednesday, she found the perfect foil in Kynan Chenai, the senior pro backing the youngster all the way as the two combined to win the trap mixed team gold with a new Asian record score.

Kynan put his individual disappointment behind and took charge of the proceedings even as Neeru, struggling to recover from being in the heavy downpour all day on Tuesday, felt physically unable to sustain the pressure, struggling to get the big scores she is known for.

The duo shot two consecutive series of 46 and then a 44 to advance as the

fourth and final qualifiers with a total of 136. While Kynan scored an impressive 73 out of a maximum of 75, Neeru stumbled in the final series with only a 19 after two series of 22s for a total of 63 but it was good enough to get into the final.

The final, though, was a complete contrast with the Indians taking charge early on and then staying on top all the way.

Kynan missed his first and only target of the final, being spot-on thereafter, scoring 19 out of a maximum 20 points.

Neeru managed 15 but it was good enough. India started with a six in the first series, followed it up with a perfect 10 to be tied with Qatar at top on 16 points. Another series of 10 put India two clear after Qatar's 8 and the difference remained till the

end, India finished on top with a 34

"You have no idea how happy I was it wasn't raining. It helped out with the targets also, it wasn't so difficult to see. Initially it was a bit tough but it brightened up towards the end of the final. Thank God it wasn't raining otherwise it would just been miserable." Kynan admitted but insisted that the conditions didn't really matter in terms of competition.

"I think more than anything else, the chase for the medal was more inspiring. As shotgun shooters, we don't really have a choice: other than lightning, we shoot in every type of condition, so we just become used to it. Having the national anthem played for you is something special and today, one of my dreams came true," he added.

Sunil bags bronze

Press Trust of India
NAGOYA

Sunil Kumar became the first Indian Greco-Roman wrestler to win two Asian Games medals after clinching a bronze in the men's 87kg event while Nisha Dahiya was knocked out on the opening day of the competition here on Wednesday.

Sunil, who had secured bronze in Hangzhou, assured his place on the podium with a technical superiority win (9-0) over Philippines' Roberts Calum Johnston. Locking his rival's right arm, the Indian effected two take downs to quickly open up a 4-0 lead. Johnston was put on ground in 'Par Terre' position, from where Sunil made more scoring moves to finish the bout in the first period itself.

The 27-year-old was left to fight for a bronze medal



Sunil... on top. REUTERS

after losing his semifinal 0-11 to Japan's Taizo Yoshida by technical superiority.

Disappointment was in store for Nisha, who blew away a lead in both her women's 68kg bouts to make an early exit.

Nisha lost to North Korea's Pak Sol Gum in the 1/8 phase — on bigger scoring move criterion — and went down to South Korea's Park Hyeonyeong 'by fall' in the repechage round.

THE INDIA SHOW

A look at some Indian performances on Wednesday:

Archery: Finals: Compound: Men's team: bt China; Women's team: bt China; Mixed team: bt South Korea.

Boxing: Semifinals: Women: 75kg: Lovlina bt Bogdanova (Kaz); 60kg: Priya lost to Chengyu (Chn), bagged bronze; Men: 90kg: Kapil lost to Khabibullaev (Uzb), bagged bronze.

Golf: Individual (round 1): Men: Saptak (T3), Veer and Yuvraj (T23); Women: Pranavi (second), Diksha and Aditi (T18).

Hockey: Women (semifinal): bt South Korea 2-0.

Shooting: Trap mixed team final: Neeru & Kynan (gold); 25m rapid fire pistol men individual

qualification (stage 1): Anish (fifth).

Squash: Quarterfinals: Women's team: bt Singapore 2-0; Men's team: bt Kuwait 2-0.

Tennis: Men: Third round: Dhakshineswar lost to Chun-hsin (Tpe) 3-6, 4-6; Nagal bt Fomin (Uzb) 6-3, 6-2; Doubles (quarterfinals): Anirudh & Sriram Balaji lost to Fumin & Tianhui (Chn) 7-6(4), 6-7(7), [8-10]; Yuki & Dhakshineswar lost to Chenjui & Yu-hsiou (Tpe) 6-7(5), 3-6. Mixed doubles (second round): Rutuja & Yuki lost to Su-wei & Chun-hsin (Tpe) 3-6, 4-6.

Wrestling: Men's Greco-Roman 87kg bronze medal match: Sunil bt Roberts (Phi); Women's 68kg repechage: Nisha lost to Hyeonyeong (Kor).

Lovlina advances to final; Priya, Kapil earn bronze

Press Trust of India
NISHIO (JAPAN)

Lovlina Borgohain scripted history by becoming the first Indian woman boxer to reach back-to-back Asian Games finals, while debutants Priya Ghanghas and Kapil Pokhariya claimed bronze medals here on Wednesday.

Last edition's silver medalist Lovlina edged reigning 70kg world champion Natalya Bogdanova of Kazakhstan 3-2 in a closely fought 75kg semifinal to assure herself of at least a silver.

However, 20-year-old Priya, making her Asian Games debut, went down 1-4 to former world champion Yang Chengyu of China in a bruising 60kg semifinal.

Another Indian debutant, Kapil suffered a similar 1-4 defeat against reigning world champion Turabek Khabibullaev of Uzbekistan in the 90kg semifinal and had to be content with a bronze.

India will thus have three boxers — Lovlina, Parveen Hooda (65kg) and Ankush Panghal (80kg) fighting for gold on Friday.

Indian boxers have already bettered their medal tally from the previous edition, with six medals assured this time compared to four in 2023, when they won one silver and three bronze.

Alongside Priya and Kapil, super-heavyweight boxer Narendra Berwal



Priya... podium finish on Games debut. SAI MEDIA



Kapil. SAI MEDIA

will also go home with a bronze medal.

Lovlina overcame a slow start to edge past Kazakhstan's Bogdanova in a closely fought contest, with a dominant second round proving decisive.

Good experience

"It was a good experience because this is my second Asian Games, and last time I had a silver medal. So this time I will definitely try to get a gold medal. Let's see what happens in the final," Lovlina said.

INDIANS IN ACTION

A look at some Indian players/teams who will compete on Thursday (all times IST):

Archery: Compound women's individual: Quarterfinal: Chikitha vs. Ashrafah (Ina), 5.30 a.m.; semifinal, 6.35 a.m.; final, 7.10 a.m.; Compound men's individual: Quarterfinal: Ganesh vs. Chen (Tpe), 9.45 a.m.; semifinal, 10.35 a.m.; final, 11.10 a.m.

Cricket: Men (semifinal): vs. Sri Lanka, 10 a.m.

Hockey: Men (semifinal): vs. Pakistan, 1 p.m.

Shooting: 25m rapid fire pistol men individual qualification (stage 2) — Anish, 6.10 a.m.; final, noon.

Squash: Semifinals: Women's team: vs. Hong Kong, 7 a.m.; Men's team: vs. Malaysia, 1 p.m.

Tennis: Men (quarterfinal): Nagal vs. Yibing (Chn), noon.

Volleyball: Men (quarterfinal): vs. Pakistan, 6.30 a.m.

Wrestling: Men's Greco-Roman 77kg (1/8 finals): Aman vs. Tuvshinbaatar (Mgl), 7.20 a.m.; Women's 62kg (1/8 finals): Mansi vs. Irina (Kaz), 7.30 a.m.; Men's Greco-Roman: 60kg (1/4 finals): Sumit vs. TBC, 7.55 a.m.; 97kg (1/4 finals): Nitesh vs. Agamammedov (Tkm), 8.15 a.m.

INBRIEF



Vaishnavi scalps six as India-A takes control of ‘Test’

Vaishnavi Sharma's haul of six for 52 handed India-A a huge advantage as the hosts led Australia-A by 322 runs at stumps on day two of the only women's "Test" here on Wednesday.

The scores: India-A 364 in 103.3 overs (Shubha Satheesh 59, Tanisha Singh 92, Niki Prasad 91; Lilly Mills 4/98, Charli Knott 3/82) & 134/2 in 27.5 overs (Priya Punia 59, Yastika Bhatia 33 n.o) vs Australia-A 176 in 63.4 overs (Rachel Trenaman 45; Vaishnavi Sharma 6/52).

ICC World Cup 2027 schedule to be announced today

The International Cricket Council (ICC) will unveil the schedule for the ICC Men's Cricket World Cup 2027 in Cape Town on Thursday. It will mark the one-year countdown to the tournament, which will commence on October 2, 2027, with the final scheduled for Sunday, November 21, 2027. The event will also see the opening of the ticket ballot for fans, as per a press release.

Brazil's Raphinha out of India clash with injury

Raphinha was released by Brazil on Wednesday because of a thigh injury. The Brazilian Football Confederation said Raphinha had a minor muscle edema and no replacement player will be called up for the friendly match against India.

LIVE TELECAST

Irani Cup: day 1, JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m.

India-A vs Australia-A: Second 'Test' day 3, JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m.

Cricket: Asian Games (Men): India vs Sri Lanka, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 10.30 a.m.

Football: Nations League, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 8.30 p.m.

Cricket: Men's ODI WC schedule unveil, Star Sports 1, 2 & Jio-Hotstar, 8.30 p.m.

Asian Games: Sony Sports Ten 2, 3, 5 & JioHotstar, 5.30 a.m. (Friday)

India breaks down a stubborn Korea

Ishika and Salima sound the board in the space of four minutes to put the women's hockey team one step away from regaining gold

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
GIFU

Indian women dominated the proceedings and did everything except finding a way to overcome a stubborn South Korean defence till the end of the third quarter. But they eventually won 2-0 to reach the Asian Games hockey final at the Gifu Prefectural Green Stadium here on Wednesday.

Having missed the bus last time around with the semifinal loss to China before taking home bronze, India will be hoping to not only avenge its defeat but also book a ticket for the LA Olympics after the defend-



Finally there: India struggled with penalty corner conversion before Ishika broke the deadlock. AHF

ing champion beat Japan 4-2 in the shootout. The teams were tied goalless at the end of regulation time in the other last-four game.

India started on an aggressive note and had its chance, the first of its 10 penalty corners coming in the fourth minute, but Deepi-

ka's shot was saved. The sequence was repeated several times through the match – India's PC, Korea's defending and stalemate. For a long time, it looked like Korea was content simply sitting back and defending. There was barely any attempt to attack or even break into the Indian third. At times, the Indians, too, were clueless on how to proceed against an opponent which did little by way of action. Most of the contest was confined to the Korean half as India tried to find the opening goal.

The deadlock was finally broken in the 44th minute when Ishika turned in a perfectly-placed pass off India's eighth PC with a reverse shot.

Four minutes later, Salima Tete's cross from the right deflected off a defender's stick and trickled past the goal line. Korea looked to have realised that there was no way back from there without moving up and creating a few chances of its own, which included three back-to-back PCs. But it could not get past Savita Punia.

It was a similar story in the other semifinal except that Japan was successful in keeping China at bay for the entire 60 minutes before going down in the shootout.

Friday's final, however, is expected to be a very different affair with both India and China known for playing a more open game than what was on display on Wednesday.

The results (semifinals): India 2 (Ishika 44, Salima Tete 48) bt South Korea 0; China 0 drew with Japan 0. *China won 4-2 in shootout.*

India runs into Pakistan in its first big test as a final spot beckons

Uthra Ganesan
GIFU

Having scored 49 goals and annihilating all opposition so far in the competition, the Indian men's hockey team will be up against its first big challenge when it takes on Pakistan in the semifinal of the Asian Games here on Thursday

At stake for the defending champion would not only be a spot in the final and being a step away from a ticket to the Olympics but also its title and reputation as the best team of the continent, something which took a battering at the recent World Cup.

Finishing eighth in the competition, despite still being the highest-ranked Asian side, questions had



Lot at stake: Harmanpreet & Co. will look to continue the good work and get a step closer to securing a ticket to the Olympics. AHF

been raised not only on India's quality but also its temperament on the big stage while also putting several of the senior players in the side under the scanner.

All those questions can well be brushed aside if India manages to get past the

would have liked. The biggest threat would be Su-fyan Khan, leading the goal-scoring charts with 11 and with crazy consistency in his conversion rate.

He got all four goals (out of seven PCs) in Pakistan's narrow 5-4 loss to Malaysia, its only one in the pool stage courtesy Malaysia's winner in the 57th minute.

India's scorers, on the other hand, have been more diverse, Dilpreet, Abhishek and Harmanpreet all among the top five.

The attack has been as expected; it's India's defence that will be tested for the first time.

On paper, India should have an easy outing; the Indians would be wary of it being anything but.

Team activities keeping us 'switched on', says Samson

Press Trust of India
NISSHIN (JAPAN)

Incessant rains have deprived India of crucial training and competition time in Japan, but constant meetings and team activities have helped the players remain "switched on", said opener Sanju Samson here on Wednesday.

The Indian team has been in Japan for the past 10 days but has only played a five-overs-a-side game against Japan on September 22.

Earlier, India's opening match in the Asia Games – a quarterfinal against Afghanistan – was abandoned after no play was possible due to rain. India will take on Sri Lanka in the semifinal on Thursday.

"We have had some good time (off the field). We have been doing some team activities. We were trying to do some practice (but the weather did not allow). But we were training and conditioning in the gym," Samson said when asked if the weather had disrupted the team's rhythm.

"We were spending time together. We were talking (about) cricket and combinations. We were having constant meetings to switch on the players when required."

Srinagar in focus as J&K aims to set the tone against RoI



Gearing up: The Rest of India players will be keen to lay down an early marker. IMRAN NISSAR

IRANI CUP

Vivek Krishnan
SRINAGAR

Wherever one's gaze turns in Srinagar, there are attractions aplenty. Not for nothing does the moniker of 'Paradise on Earth' adorn Kashmir. There is the serene Dal Lake, where *shikara* rides run from dawn to dusk.

There is the dense covering of *chinar* trees, whose leaves will morph into a canvas of crimson before carpeting the turf at the culmination of autumn.

For connoisseurs of food and drink, the multi-course *wazwan* meal and the piping hot *kahwa* tea are must-haves.

Seldom, though, has cricket figured prominently in conversations here. Sure, two ODIs were held in the 1980s at the Sher-i-Kashmir Stadium – the first between India and West Indies in 1983 left a bitter taste as an unruly crowd dug up the pitch – but India's northernmost region was always on the margins of the country's cricketing map.

Not anymore. Undeniable proof comes this week as the Sher-i-Kashmir Stadium, nestled in the foothills of the Zabarwan mountain range, hosts arguably its biggest cricketing contest since the 1980s.

From Thursday, Jammu & Kashmir will take on the Rishabh Pant-led Rest of India in the Irani Cup here. The recognition is by virtue of J&K holding aloft the Ranji Trophy for the first time in 2025-26.

The interest for the fixture was palpable on Wednesday afternoon. As both teams wrapped up their practice sessions, a queue of fans, comprising youngsters largely, patiently lined up outside one of the side gates in the hunt for passes.

When the action begins, there are players on both sides with plenty to gain.

For J&K, the curiosity revolves around how it responds to the tag of the Ranji champion.

In the Rest of India camp, there is a nice blend of proven performers like Pant and Sarfaraz Khan and young talents like Manav Suthar and Shikhar Mohan. If the contest can be as arresting as the sights of Srinagar, the city's long wait for a high-profile contest would have been worth it.

The teams (from): Jammu & Kashmir: Paras Dogra (Capt.), Shubham Khajuria, Qamran Iqbal, Yawer Hassan, Shubham Pundir, Abdul Samad, Kawalpreet Singh, Kanhaiya Wadhawan (wk), Abid Mushtaq, Sahil Lotra, Vanshaj Sharma, Sunil Kumar, Umar Nazir, Lone Nasir Muzaffar, Rohit Sharma.

Rest of India: Rishabh Pant (Capt. & wk), Sanat Sangwan, Sudip Gharami, Sarfaraz Khan, Ayush Doseja, R. Smaran, Shikhar Mohan, Aryan Juyal (wk), Anukul Roy, Manav Suthar, Saransh Jain, Akash Deep, Mukesh Kumar, Mukesh Choudhary, Aryan Pandey.

Pant ready for the ups and downs

Vivek Krishnan
SRINAGAR

His teammates had dispersed. So had the net bowlers. More than 30 minutes after he had begun batting at the farthest net, Rishabh Pant, set to lead Rest of India in the Irani Cup against Jammu & Kashmir from Thursday, seemed oblivious to the surroundings at the Sher-i-Kashmir Stadium.

If the 28-year-old conveyed the impression of having no other distractions at that moment, it is because he is confined to this one format for the time being.

He isn't in the ODI and T20I teams, which means that his next international assignment could be some time away – India plays two Tests against New Zealand in the second half of November.

Pant isn't scratching his head over the imponderables. "There will be ups and downs. When you want to have an international career for 15-20 years, you have to go through these things. So, it's that kind of mindset," he said at the pre-match interaction. "It's very simple. Whatever is in front of me, I will give my best. That's how I have played cricket."

Dogra backs his pacers

A little after 1 p.m., at the Barsapara in Guwahati, Aqib Nabi received his India cap from K.L. Rahul.

Less than an hour earlier, in Srinagar, Nabi was a recurring theme of the press conferences building up to the fixture.

It wasn't yet known that he would become just the third cricketer from J&K to play for India, but such had been the pacer's impact on his team's Ranji Trophy-winning exploits in 2025-26 that the two captains were asked repeatedly about Nabi's absence.

For Paras Dogra, the query was at the core of J&K's chances of not only winning the Irani Cup but also defending its Ranji title.

"Obviously, he took 60 wickets last year. But we have [other] good bowlers. This is a good sign for J&K that cricket is growing and other boys will get a chance," the 41-year-old said.



Charming: Pant makes a CRPF constable's day. IMRAN NISSAR

SNAPSHOTS



Lightning quick: Yamal scores Spain's opener after just 75 seconds against Croatia. AFP

Spain brushes aside Croatia

PARIS: Lamine Yamal netted a brace as world champion Spain continued its winning start to the UEFA Nations League with a 4-1 success in Seville against Croatia on Tuesday, while Harry Kane scored as England won in Czechia.

The results: League A: Group 3: Spain 4 (Yamal 2, 63, Pubill 31, Williams 89) bt Croatia 1 (Beljo 28); Czechia 0 lost to England 2 (Gordon 47, Kane 69).

Kohli climbs to second spot in ODI rankings

NEW DELHI: India's star batter Virat Kohli's stunning 139 not out against the West Indies in the 1st ODI has propelled him to second place in the latest ODI batting rankings.

Kohli's 55th ODI century, and 86th international hundred across formats, earned him a rating of 796 and lifted him one place in the rankings, as per the ICC website.

The former India captain now trails only teammate Shubman Gill, who strengthened his position at the top with a century of his own in the same

match. Gill leads the rankings with 816 rating points.

Mortara and de Vries to stay on at Mahindra Racing

CHENNAI: Indian team Mahindra Racing has retained Edoardo Mortara and Nyck de Vries for the upcoming 2026/27 FIA Formula E World Championship season. Season 13 marks the start of a new era for Formula E, as the series enters its fourth generation with the arrival of the state-of-the-art GEN4 cars. Since joining Mahindra Racing in 2023, Mortara and de Vries have played a pivotal role in the team's progression and development over the past three seasons and, together, have secured two victories, 10 additional podium finishes, and six pole positions. Their efforts during the 2025-26 season helped deliver Mahindra Racing its strongest campaign in Formula E to date, matching its best-ever finish of third in the Teams' Championship and scoring a record 252 points.

India-A in trouble as the top-order fails to get going

AUSA IN INDIA

Abhishek Saini
PUDUCHERRY

Neither Devdutt Padikkal (31, 46b, 4x4) nor B. Sai Sudharsan could bail India-A out from a batting slump, and the host had its back to the wall against Australia-A after the second day of the second 'Test' at the Siechem Cricket Stadium here on Wednesday.

The internationals had chipped in with runs in the first game, but Todd Murphy (two for 26) and Corey Rocchiccioli snared them and hit the spine of this Indian batting line-up. India-A was 122 for five at stumps, still 236 behind the visitors.

Rocchiccioli, with his tall release and flight, had already got deliveries to misbehave with extra bounce.

With Sai Sudharsan pushed into his crease to tackle this trepidation, the gambit was completed by Murphy, who fired a delivery full, got it to turn low and crash into the off-stump.

Padikkal was helpless to a similar delivery from Rocchiccioli.

Shaik Rasheed (36 batting, 140b, 2x4), seeing the slide, opted to stonewall to survive till stumps.

The scores: Australia-A 358 in 116.3 overs (Jason Sangha 46, Sam Harper 128) vs. India-A 122/5 in 51 overs.

Gill on the double as India hunts down 406 in style

The skipper's stroke-filled knock and his mammoth opening stand with Rohit power the second highest run-chase in ODIs; centuries by WI batters Campbell, Hope and Jangoo go in vain

WI IN INDIA

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
GUWAHATI

Through the global financial crisis, Arab Spring, the discovery of the Higgs boson, humanity's first image of a black hole, a pandemic that brought the world to a halt, and the rise of generative AI, the world has not seen a successful ODI chase in excess of 400.

The last such chase came in March 2006. On Wednesday, Shubman Gill's forensic artistry (223 n.o., 133b, 26x4, 8x6) and Rohit Sharma's slouching grandeur (101, 75b, 10x4, 6x6) came to the fore as India finally joined that rare club. Chasing down 406 with eight wickets to spare, India took an unassailable 2-0 lead in the three-match series against West Indies at the Barsapara Cricket Stadium. There is something faintly García Marquez-like about Gill's current form. The extraordinary keeps occurring with such regularity that everyone has stopped treating it as extraordinary. A hundred from him now feels like rain in Macondo: remarkable in isolation, almost routine in accumulation. This time, he doubled down on it - in double quick time.

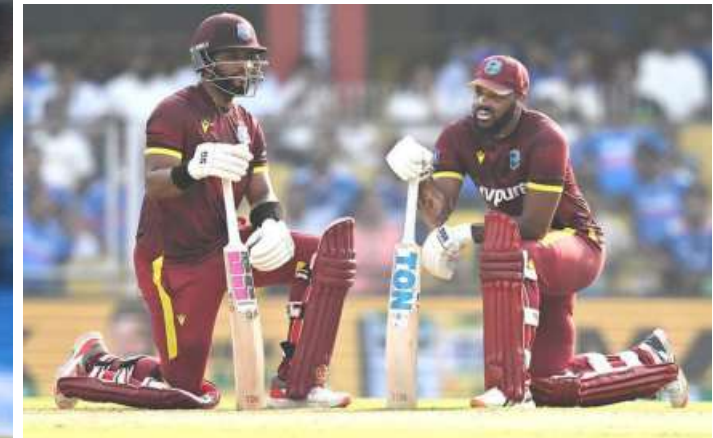
Gill's batting was silk and shrapnel. His wrists were particularly persuasive, shuffling deep into the leg-side before cutting through backward point, or flicking over midwicket with the ease of a samurai wielding a light sword. He used his feet repeatedly,



Avalanche of runs: Gill and Rohit orchestrated India's incredible pursuit after Jangoo, Campbell and Hope smashed hundreds for West Indies. RITU RAJ KONWAR

dancing down to Roston Chase and Keemo Paul and launching sixes over square-leg and cow-corner. There was precision, too: a late slice between deep-point and deep-third, a pristine punch past cover,

a full-faced drive that left mid-on stranded. Even the short ball was not safe - a 141.3-kph delivery from Alzarri Joseph disappeared into the stands off Gill's signature short-arm jab. He reached his hundred



off 62 balls, his 11th in ODIs, before going on to raise the fastest double-hundred, off 117 balls.

Gill and Rohit - who crossed 12,000 runs in the 50-over format - added 255 for the opening wicket.

Rohit once said that when he is batting well, he gets into good positions. Watch him on a good day and you see it. A slight adjustment of the feet, a quiet transfer of weight, a subtle alignment of shoul-

ders and eyes. No reaching. No lunging. No rescue missions. Just a man arriving exactly where he needs to be, exactly when he needs to be there. The shot feels inevitable because the position was perfect.

Earlier, John Campbell wasn't to be trifled with. After all, when a man treats a missed hundred as unfinished business, he is best given a wide berth. If his 60-ball 62 in the first ODI was useful, his 68-ball



SCOREBOARD

WEST INDIES
John Campbell c Dhir b Gurnoor 101 (68b, 9x4, 5x6), Keacy Carty c Dhir b Prasidh 9 (10b, 2x4), Shai Hope c Nabi b Kuldeep 104 (94b, 8x4, 3x6), Amir Jangoo c Ruturaj b Jadeja 114 (77b, 13x4, 3x6), Sherfane Rutherford c sub (Jaiswal) b Gurnoor 0 (1b), Roston Chase (not out) 29 (25b, 4x4), Keemo Paul c Kohli b Kuldeep 3 (8b), Alzarri Joseph c Rohit b Jadeja 8 (10b, 1x4), Shamar Joseph (not out) 14 (8b, 1x4, 1x6); Extras (b-1, lb-1, w-20, nb-1): 23; Total (for seven wkts. in 50 overs): 405.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-37 (Carty, 4.6 overs), 2-147 (Campbell, 18.1), 3-329 (Hope, 39.6), 4-330 (Rutherford, 40.2), 5-348 (Jangoo, 42.2), 6-369 (Paul, 45.1), 7-385 (Joseph, 47.3).

INDIA BOWLING
Prasidh 5-0-45-1, Nabi 8.5-0-84-0, Gurnoor 10-0-96-2, Dhir 6.1-0-38-0, Jadeja 10-0-75-2, Kuldeep 10-0-65-2

INDIA
Rohit Sharma lbw b Seales 101 (75b, 10x4, 6x6), Shubman Gill (not out) 223 (133b, 26x4, 8x6), Virat Kohli c Rutherford b Shamar 29 (19b, 3x4, 1x6), Ruturaj Gaikwad (not out) 31 (37b, 2x4); Extras (lb-2, nb-3, w-17): 22; Total (for two wkts. in 43.3 overs): 406.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-255 (Rohit, 26.2), 2-320 (Kohli, 32.1).

WEST INDIES BOWLING
Seales 8-0-78-1, Alzarri 8-0-89-0, Shamar 6-0-52-1, Paul 3-0-49-0, Chase 8.3-0-63-0, Lawes 10-0-73-0.

Toss: India; **PoM:** Gill.
India won by eight wickets with 39 balls remaining to lead series 2-0.

Third and final ODI: October 3, New Chandigarh, 2 p.m.

101 (9x4, 5x6) here was punitive. Campbell, skipper Shai Hope (104, 94b, 8x4, 3x6), and Amir Jangoo (114, 77b, 13x4, 3x6) formed the Caribbean century cartel.



Chhattisgarh State Industrial Development Corporation Limited
(A Government of Chhattisgarh Undertaking)
(ISO 9001 : 2015 Certified)
1st Floor, Udyog Bhawan, Ring Road No.1, Telibandha, Raipur (C.G.)- 492006
CIN: U45203CT1981SG001853, PAN: AABCM6288N, GST Regn No. 22AABCM6288N5ZY
Phone: 0771-6621000 Fax: 0771-2583794
Website: www.csidc.in, Email address:csidc.cg@nic.in, csidc_raipur@yahoo.com

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (3rd Call)
(Through e-Procurement Portal Only)

NIT No. 18/CSIDC/E.E./Division-II/2026-27

Raipur, Dated 30/09/2026

Chhattisgarh State Industrial Development Corporation Ltd., Raipur (CSIDC), a Government of Chhattisgarh Undertaking constituted under the Companies Act, engaged in Industrial Infrastructure Development & Other Related Activities in the State invites online tender for the following works:-

S. No.	Name of Work	Registered Contractor in CGPWD or in appropriate class in other dep't.	Probable Amount of Contract (PAC) (INR Crore)	Time allowed (including rainy season)	EMD (INR Lac)	Cost of Tender Document (Including GST 18%)
01.	Infrastructure development works i/c Roads, R.C.C. drain Hume Pipe Culverts, water supply system, Street light, Shed works, Shopping Complex & Building works for Proposed New Industrial area at Village-Kosmanda, Block Palari District-Baloda Bazar BhatlaPara (C.G.)	'Class-B	7.29	09 Months	729000/- (Through Online https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in)	11800/- (Through Online https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in)

The tender document containing detailed terms & conditions, scope of works and other details can be downloaded from the web portal (website) <https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> from **30/09/2026** Time 17:01 and shall be submitted online only. Amendment in tender, if any, will only be uploaded on the website and shall not be published in any newspaper.

NOTE:- The interested tenderers for online submission of tender may contact CG eProc Helpdesk. Operated by **Mjunction Services Limited**, they may reach Helpdesk using 18004199140 (therein press 2 for CG e-Proc) or you can email them at Helpdesk.eproc@cgswan.gov.in.

Executive Engineer
Division-II

Samvad - 49247/3



NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY
CORRIGENDUM
Website-www.ner.indianrailways.gov.in
Date: 29-09-2026

Under noted amendment is hereby made against tender No. 26265166 due on 30-09-2026 Tender Notice No.-11 Dt. 07-09-2026 (Item No.-14)

Item No.-14, Item Description: NIT Conditions- (Commercial-Compliance S.No.-04), Existing Entry: Documents uploading Not Allowed. Amended as: Documents uploading-Allowed (Mandatory). **Item Description:** Delivery Period, Existing Entry: Within 06 months. Amended as: Within 04 months. **Item Description:** Tender Opening date-with time, Existing Entry: 30-09-2026, 11:30 am Amended as: 16-10-2026, 11:30 am Description may be viewed at IREPS website.

All other terms and conditions will be remained unchanged.

Note: Above information may be seen on N.E. Railway website www.ner.indianrailways.gov.in & Govt. of India's website www.tenders.gov.in

Principal Chief Material Manager,
CPRO/S-66 Gorakhpur

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NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY
E-TENDERING NOTICE

Divisional Railway Manager (Electrical/General), North Eastern Railway, Varanasi for and on behalf of President of India invites Tenders through Online E-Tendering for the following work:-

Sl.No.-01, Tender Type: Open Tender, Tender reference No.: E-Tender-CHG-03-26-27, Name of Work: Supply of C Check kit for Kirloskar & Greaves make diesel Engines and Modification of switch board cabinet of LHB AC coaches with single power supply connection distribution at input of MPCB/MCB's RMPU AC unit at switch board cabinet of LHB AC coaches as per RDSO modification sheet-modification sheet no. RDSO-/PE/MS/AC/097-2025 (Rev 0) dt 13-05-2025 over BSB Division. Approx. Cost. (in Rs.): ₹ 45,67,745.66, Earnest Money (in Rs.): ₹ 91,400/-. Completion period: 04 Months. Date & time of Closing Tender: 22-10-2026, 14:30 Hrs., Date & time of Opening Tender: 22-10-2026, 14:30 Hrs., **Sl.No.-02,** Tender Type: Single Tender, Tender reference No.: E-Tender-L-35-26-27, Name of Work: Annual Maintenance Contract of 04 Nos of Johnson Make Lift installed on FOB (G+1) at BNRS (02 Nos), CPR (01 No) & SV (01 No) Railway stations through OEM for 05 Years. Approx. Cost. (in Rs.): ₹ 32,33,652/-. Earnest Money (in Rs.): ₹ 64,700/-. Completion period: 60 Months. Date & time of Closing Tender: 22-10-2026, 14:30 Hrs. Date & time of Opening Tender: 22-10-2026, 14:30 Hrs.

• For full details of above E-Tender work and to participate in tenders please visit Indian Railway Website www.tenders.gov.in Sr.Divl. Electrical Engineer/General, CPRO/Vidyt-201 Varanasi

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IDCOSH
NEW OPPORTUNITIES

File No. HO/P&C/EST/E-3051/01/2026 28487 Dt.25.09.2026

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF GENERAL MANAGER (P&C), IDCO, IDCO TOWER, BHUBANESWAR

Bid Identification No.P&C/EST/E-29/2026-27

NOTICE INVITING TENDER UNDER NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING THROUGH e-Procurement

Name of the Work : "Construction of 3 no.s BT road at EMC Park, Info valley-II, Bhubaneswar, Khordha"

1. Value of the Work : Rs.423.85 Lakhs (Approx.)
2. Period of completion : 04 (Four) Calendar Months

Other Details :

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender On-Line for Bidding
Chief General Manager (P&C), IDCO, IDCO Towers, Bhubaneswar-751022	Bid ID No.:- P&C/EST/E-29/2026-27	17:00 Hours of dt. 30.09.2026 17:00 Hours of dt. 14.10.2026

Tender details can be seen from the e-procurement portal: www.tendersorissa.gov.in. Corrigendum or Addendum if any will not be published in newspapers and can be seen in e-procurement portal as well as in IDCO website.

Sd/- Chief General Manager (P&C), IDCO, Bhubaneswar
4001/339/2627 OIPR-4001/4075/11/26-27/0122

कार्यालय नगर पालिक निगम सतना (म.प्र.)

N.I.T क्र. 05 (E.T.) / विद्युत-शाखा / न.पा.नि. / 2026-27 सतना, दिनांक 28.09.2026

निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

नगर पालिक निगम सतना द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु केन्द्रीयकृत प्रणाली में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से ऑन लाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा का विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाईट <https://www.mptenders.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है।

क्र.	निविदा क्र.व जारी दिनांक	टेंडर क्रमांक	कार्य का नाम	अनुमानित लागत	अमानत राशि	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य	कार्य की समाप्ति
01	05 28.09.2026	2026_UAD -539210.1	नवीन एल.ई.डी. स्ट्रीट लाइट सामग्री क्रय, स्थापना एवं रख-रखाव कार्य।	1,44,76,600/-	1,44,800/-	12,500/-	45 दिवस

1. निविदा प्रपत्र वेबसाईट <https://www.mptenders.gov.in> पर दिनांक 29.09.2026 समय 10:30 से दिनांक 28.10.2026 समय 17:30 बजे तक ऑनलाइन भुगतान करने पर प्राप्त हो सकेगा। 2. निविदा से संबंधित किसी भी प्रकार के संशोधन का प्रकाशन ऑनलाइन <https://www.mptenders.gov.in> की वेबसाईट पर ही किया जावेगा, पृथक से समाचार पत्र में प्रकाशन नहीं किया जावेगा।

विभागाध्यक्ष (विद्युत-शाखा)
नगर पालिक निगम, सतना (म.प्र.), सतना, दिनांक 28.09.2026



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Serving To Empower

Human Resources
Corporate Headquarters
M.A. Road, Srinagar
Phone No's-0194-2713121-24

Apply For - Contractual Positions

In continuation to Notification No.: JKB/HR/Rectt/2026-412 Dated: 09.09.2026, it is notified that the date for receipt of applications for the advertised positions of Zonal Security Officers and FL Counsellors is extended from 01.10.2026 till 07.10.2026.

Interested candidates are requested to apply through the link made available on Banks website (jkb.bank.in) under careers tab. The candidate shall have to pay the requisite fee of Rs. 500/- per application.

The detailed notification for the Contractual Positions is available on Bank's website.

Note: Candidates who have already applied for the advertised positions in response to Notification No.: JKB/HR/Rectt/2026-412 Dated: 09.09.2026, need not to apply again.

No.: JKB/HR/Rectt/2026-435
Dated:-30.09.2026

Sd/-
General Manager-HR

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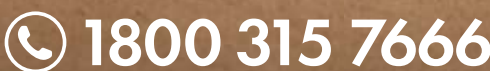
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TVSCREDIT EAST DELHI: Binsar TVS: Durgapuri-982121880 Khair-9821258420 Sonia Vihar-9821260573 Mandoli Extn.-9821260735 Sherpur Chowk-8527348216 Zero Pusta, Shastri Park-9821264718 Baijwa TVS: Krishna Nagar-8527320253 Jheel Rajgarh-9310527752 Mayapuri-9654803663
SD TVS: Dilshad Garden-9821272498 Kondli-7290091183 Mani Pusta road, Gandhi Nagar - 9821268264 G. K. TVS: Laxmi Nagar - 9821271831 Mayur Vihar Phase-3-6366448953 Madhu Vihar - 9821259935 New Ashok Nagar - 6366448954 MCR TVS: Saraswati Vihar-9821266109
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Narela-9218103704 Balaji TVS: Samaypur Badli-9312100112 SOUTH DELHI: Om TVS: Lajpat Nagar-9821272463 Okhla Industrial Area Phase-1 9821261765 Badarpur, Jaitpur-9821263038 Pulpradapur-9821264982 Shaheen Bagh-9821266451 Munirka - 9174524444 Ahishiva TVS: Khanpur - 9266364442
Aaya Nagar - 8447817459 Chhatrapur-9650004266, Main railway road-9311299301 Surryaan TVS: Mahipalpur - 999087739 Ride TVS: Bikaji Cama Place - 9582890609, Ashram - 95828902300 Thuglakabad - 9560063532, Nawada - 9582890101, Vincent TVS - Adhchini - 8796449790, NE
-9389985534, K K TVS: Kapashera-9821261661. CENTRAL DELHI: Balaji TVS: Shastri Nagar - 9821271672 Roshanara Road - 9870326061 Shahzada bagh - 6366448959 Sabharwal TVS: Karol Bagh- 9821258099 Tilak Nagar - 9821212911 YM TVS-Daryaganj: 9999388189 YM TVS Malkaganj-93193910033
WEST DELHI: Subhash Nagar - 9821276304 Nawada - 9821276377 Dabri More-9821254451 Outer Ring Road, Vikas Puri-9821256445 Dynamic TVS: Dwarka - 982171426 Palam-9870327324 Ramphol Chowk - Sec-7 9870327413 Uttam Nagar-9870324753 K K TVS: Nangloi - 9821271618 Vikas Nagar
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From shooting at haystacks to shooting for gold

Every archer knows the wait between release and arrival, that held breath when nothing can be changed and everything is decided. For Chikitha, the wait lasted years. It began in a backyard, ran through lockdowns and a snapped bowstring, and ended in Aichi-Nagoya with a double triumph



REUTERS & PTI

Anirudh Velamuri

The two gold medals she has snapped up at the 2026 Asian Games have catapulted the extremely shy compound archer Chikitha Taniparthi into the national headlines. The 21-year-old, who hails from a modest farming family in Peddapalli in Telangana, is a stranger to stardom and the sprinkling of opulence that sporting achievements usually carry along in India.

There are no fancy routines or competition-day playlists yet. She doesn't even carry a pair of earphones. All she has is a burning hunger to become India's most decorated archer ever. And she's off to quite a start.

For all the reticence, Chikitha - a huge Mahesh Babu fan - finds inspiration in films that are of a more audacious ilk.

"There was a movie Ram Charan did last year called Game Changer. After watching that - and it usually happens when I watch certain films - I thought, what should I do or learn from this? I myself should change the game where I am," Chikitha told *The Hindu* a few weeks before setting out to Japan for the Asiad.

"Now, everyone says, whatever rank Chikitha is in, she will somehow change the game and come up. Similarly, I watched a film called Biker, where the message blared, 'No fear.' It all registers somewhere."

Of betrayal and faith

That itch to push beyond the ordinary is a Taniparthi family trait. Her father, Srinivas Rao - a huge sports enthusiast - combed newspapers for summer camps his own childhood never offered.

"Naanna (father) didn't have any such facilities when he was growing up, so he was keen to ensure that I had access to all that, within our means."

In school, Chikitha tried her hand at a multitude of options including volleyball, badminton, basketball and kho kho. But Srinivas wanted his child to pursue an individual discipline. Towards that end, she earned a black belt in karate. But archery was destined to be the one to stick with.

"Team sports are riddled with politics. Since archery is an individual game, whatever we do is directly visible and we do what we do for ourselves."

The year was 2018. Chikitha's uncle, on her father's request, had got her a recurve bow from Decathlon with which she trained behind her house, shooting at haystacks. Eventually, she and a few of her classmates went to the Police Training Center to try and find a coach to teach them. There, someone asked her to switch to a compound bow and took money from Srinivas for the same, only to disappear without a trace.

Disappointed but not disillusioned, the father and daughter persisted with the sport. Chikitha moved away from recurve and towards compound.

"Recurve bow needs a lot of practice and power. You need to train every single day. If you return after resting for a few days, you'll see so many changes and will have to rework it all. With compound, I could train for two hours each in the morning and evening. It needed the archer to set themselves mentally and keep getting better."

The next pursuit became trying to purchase a compound bow, but the COVID-19 pandemic arrived soon after.

"Our classes all went online, so I could train every day. At that point I didn't know what a national medal was, but I wanted to win one."

"During Covid, my father had set up a target and a 50m path so I could shoot. He would go to the field every morning. My brother and I would go running every morning along the edges of our field. That is when I became really fit. In fact, my father also joined us and improved," Chikitha recalled.

"Eventually I left for Sonipat, and my father settled back into the duties of the house. The family's fitness streak sort of snapped there."

Srinivas pushed beyond his means to support his daughter's dream. He even sold the family's paddy harvester. Meanwhile, YouTube videos formed the bedrock of Chikitha's technical base, and one of the archers she grew to idolise - Abhishek Verma - would become her mentor.

Eventually, the District Collector's office sanctioned funds for a compound bow. As she looked for a coach and a good training centre, Chikitha chanced upon the contact details of My Choice Archery Store, an equipment outlet run by Abhishek and his wife Sonali in New Delhi.

Guiding light

"I got her number from the shop they run and I knew she was Abhishek anna's wife. He and his coach (Lokesh Chand Pal)



agreed to take me in for training at the Yamuna Sports Complex for five days."

This was in August 2021. As the world found a way to open up again, so did Chikitha's prospects as an archer. Her uncle chipped in with funds for the trip to the capital.

There, Abhishek told Srinivas to leave Chikitha's well-being to him.

The first goal was a sub-junior medal.

"I didn't know much about archery, but I used to watch Abhishek anna's videos and check with my father if I was getting things right. Anna then told me that my strength was good, but he changed my anchor technique."

"In the mornings, he used to let me shoot 50-100 arrows. In the evenings, there would be no shooting. We just trained holding the bow and arrow in place. This was to develop patience. I learnt all my basics there at the Yamuna Sports Complex."

Chikitha entered the senior nationals in preparation for the sub-junior event and got a very low score there. Her mentor had notes, and the pair eventually struck off the first box in what would become a long checklist of turfs to conquer.

She then participated in selection trials to make it to the Sports Authority of India's National Centre of Excellence in Sonipat. There, coach Vivek Kumar took her under his wing.

"After my father, he is the only person I open up to after tournaments and cry with," Chikitha said.

"In 2021, I was in Hyderabad for the National Ranking Archery Tournament. Abhishek told me that there was a talented girl I should meet. Her father brought her to the hotel we were staying in. This girl was so small and frail. I asked her if she wanted to go to Sonipat. She nodded in agreement, but there were tears too," Vivek told *The Hindu*.

Nonetheless, he persisted. "If a player like Abhishek recommends someone, you cannot ignore that. He told us she would become a good archer like Jyothi Surekha."

Abhishek, it turned out, was right. The parallels between Chikitha and Jyothi are endless. Both are introverts by nature,

content to shuttle between the training field and the gym. Both follow instructions to the letter, even when that means shooting 300-odd arrows, and both are always early, rain or shine.

Vivek remembers Chikitha clinging to her father until the moment they parted. Slowly, Sonipat won her over. By night, she had found the courage to make a request: biryani. The coaches understood how hard it is for someone from South India to move to a diet where rotis reign, and they indulged her.

Any doubts about her potential evaporated at the trials ahead of the 2022 Asian Games. She missed qualification but finished a commendable seventh, enough to convince her coaches that she could be shaped into an athlete who would make India proud on the global stage.

Ask Chikitha why she likes archery and three bullet points follow. "First, because, as my dad wanted, it's an individual sport. Second, archery is a sport where I can concentrate and focus with no distractions. Third, Anna told me, 'You are a champion, and you will continue to be.'"

Others' faith in her sowed the seeds of Chikitha's ambitions; formal training is teaching her to nurture them herself. That process has not been without its hiccups. In 2024, Chikitha struggled to place among the top 16 and had lost motivation mid-season.

"That period was a struggle and I couldn't accept it. Before the national games, I wanted to get selected, but I was nowhere near the top. I was working with high poundage, and I said if I hit any more (shooting arrows), I might get injured. I didn't feel like shooting. It took me some time to recover from that. I went to Tirupati, tonsured my head, prayed very hard," she recalled.

Through every hardship, Chikitha never once thought of abandoning archery.

When her first substantial prize money arrived, after the 2023 National Games in Goa, she spent it on arrows, stockpiled for practice. A fresh set every few months is her idea of a treat.

"It is not about the money; it does not matter as long as the results come my way."

Ask Chikitha what she is proud of and, along with the golds, she may mention the gift of deep sleep. Thunder can rattle every window, but she will slumber on.

"I don't get sleep only when thoughts come to me, which happens when everything is silent."

Then she went to Japan and became the lightning. Whether or not she slept through the aftermath, India did not. Two golds flashed across the sky, and a sport that thought it knew its stars blinked in the glare.

THE GIST

- ▼ Chikitha is India's first double gold medalist at the 2026 Asian Games, triumphing in the women's compound team and mixed team events
- ▼ Chikitha and Sahil (mixed team) also helped secure India a quota for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics
- ▼ A Decathlon bow, shooting at haystacks in her backyard and YouTube tutorials were her first training ground, while lockdown and a snapped bowstring couldn't stop her
- ▼ Her father sold his harvester so his daughter could chase a target. In Aichi-Nagoya, she paid it back in gold
- ▼ When Abhishek failed to make the cut for the Asian Games, he told his mentee to become the Asian Games champion and bring him the toy as a gift. The 21-year-old now has two, with a chance to bid for a third in the individual event

Subatomic ambitions take five Indian school students to CERN

The students say they spent hours every day preparing for the 'Beamline for Schools' competition, organised by the European Laboratory for Particle Physics for high school students around the world; they tried to measure how often a charged pion turns into a neutral one when it hits 'light' atoms

T.V. Padma
NEW DELHI

A group of Indian school students are among the five winning teams of the 13th edition of the 'Beamline for Schools' competition, a physics competition for high school students from all around the world organised by CERN, the European Laboratory for Particle Physics, in Geneva.

The Indian team, named "attoPION", comprises Nenavath Abhay Vivek, Sidhartha Aniket Jaiswal, Ayush Bhardwaj, Aarush Mandala, and Aritra Sadhukhan. They are from Bansal Junior College Nizamabad; Greenwood High International School, Bengaluru; The Shri Ram Global School, Greater Noida; and Purv International School, Durgapur.

They found each other through different science competitions they participated in.

Tracking pions

A beamline is a facility that provides high-energy fluxes of subatomic particles that can be used to conduct experiments in different fields, including fundamental physics, material science and medicine. The other four winning teams are from Bangladesh, Türkiye, the U.K., and the U.S.

The Indian students' project was based on a process called pion charge exchange. In particle physics, pions are subatomic particles that can have a positive, negative or neutral charge. The students tried to measure how often a charged pion turns into a neutral one when it hits "light" atoms like lithium and beryllium, and they looked at this change of charge at specific energy levels.

These readings are of interest for the Deep Underground Neutrino Experiment, a large physics experiment under construction in the U.S.

When neutrinos hit an atom, they produce pions. If the pions change their charge before they even leave the atom, it can mess up the data scientists see, the students said. Recording how often this change takes place in lithium and beryllium will allow scientists to model it correctly in their simulations.

Learning the basics

When the students started, they did not have any formal training in particle physics.

"We were just a group of 11th and 12th graders who were obsessed with the subject," they said. "In the beginning, it felt like we were trying to solve a high-level puzzle without having the box with the picture on it. We spent so much time reading papers and talking to mentors just to get our heads around the theory."

The students said they spent several hours every day in the three to four weeks before the competition. While the first week was mostly about recruiting and forming a team, the next three weeks were a complete grind.

The team started with the basics, with



A view of the Large Hadron Collider at CERN. CERN

Griffiths Introduction to Elementary Particles (1987) serving as their main reference book. They also said *A Tour of the Subatomic Zoo* (1992) gave them their first big picture and that YouTube lectures by experts at the Indian Institute of Science, Bengaluru, and courses on the National Programme on Technology Enhanced Learning (NPTEL) kept them going.

"Once we had the basics, we moved to CERN documentation and research papers from CERN and other institutions," they said. "For the Geant4 simulations, we used CERN's official documentation and some of their preloaded models, which we then tweaked to test our own idea in the initial stages."

Sometimes, understanding just one

research paper or one detector concept would take them days. "We just kept going until the physics finally started making sense," one of the students said. "We were pulling all-nighters to finish the proposal before the deadline."

"We feel once you start counting hours, your focus shifts from learning to the clock. We just kept going until the physics finally started making sense."

Physics that could make sense to high-schoolers was one constraint. Two others were that the participants had to design an experiment from scratch and that it could actually be run at CERN.

So the students proposed a setup to collect data across different energy levels and different types of atoms to see the variations.

"We were nervous because we were so

new to this, but after a lot of collaboration and refining the technical details, we felt confident enough to hit the submit button," they said.

A love for physics in particular was a strong motivation. "We thought of it as an opportunity to try something new and unconventional and learn something during that process," they added.

Mentoring helps

Once the team was in place, the students hunted for mentors to guide them. They started by cold-emailing several PhD scholars, postdocs, and graduate students across universities in India and abroad.

They struck luck with Manu Srivastava, a doctoral scholar at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology in the U.S., and received additional feedback on their experimental design from Laxman Mekala at IIT-Bombay.

"My role was purely a supervisory one," Mr. Srivastava said. "The students came up with different ideas and worked out all the calculations themselves." He added: "I only had to guide them about which ideas would be more worthwhile to pursue, so in a way just providing direction and giving minimal feedback on their work."

The students' discussions among themselves and with Mr. Srivastava were online. "To me, that is a powerful example of how technology is becoming a unifying force at the grassroots level in India, allowing talented students from different regions to come together around a shared scientific goal. Such collaborations would have been much more difficult to imagine even a decade ago," Mr. Srivastava said.

He added that the students' achievement was made more remarkable by the competition's scale. Beamline for Schools is a prestigious international science competition for high-school students and this year attracted more than 700 proposals from around the world.

Just the start

A lot of students think competitions like this are too tough and not for them, the students said.

"We want to tell them that sometimes the biggest opportunities start from a very simple question or a crazy idea," they said. "Curiosity is enough to start. If you are curious enough to try, keep learning and do not give up when it gets difficult, you might end up in places you never imagined."

Looking ahead, the students would like to keep the momentum going, stay connected as a team, and collaborate with other physicists. They would also like to engage in outreach for the BL45 program to help other students.

"All of us are definitely planning to pursue careers in STEM and keep doing our own research. Being at CERN is just the start for us," they said.

(T.V. Padma is a science journalist based in New Delhi. tvpadma_10@yahoo.co.in)



The SpaceX Starship rocket lifts off on its 14th test flight from Texas in the U.S. on Monday, AP

SpaceX Starship engine failure could hit NASA's lunar mission

Reuters

The Starship engine failure that nearly foiled the orbital debut of SpaceX's next-generation spacecraft on its 14th uncrewed test flight may complicate NASA's ability to meet its time frame for astronaut missions to the moon.

Starship, designed in part to carry large payloads to space, is one of two vehicles vying to become the first craft that NASA will use as early as 2028 to land humans on the moon and bring them safely home, a feat last achieved in 1972 at the end of the Apollo era.

While Starship accomplished a number of key objectives in its latest test launch from Texas on Monday, the mission was cut short by several hours after a malfunction of its propulsion system.

Despite the unexpected shutdown of one of its three main Raptor engines following Starship separation from its lower-stage booster rocket, flight controllers proceeded with sending the spacecraft to orbit for its first-ever commercial satellite deployment.

Determining what caused the engine glitch remains critical to SpaceX's bottom line. But the stakes are potentially higher for NASA, as a Starship moon-landing vehicle would rely on the same engine system for transporting astronauts through space to and from the lunar surface.

How big a blow to Starship's development progress the engine snafu becomes depends on whether it turns out to be "a one-off failure of a single part" or points to a larger design problem that requires upgrades "across the fleet," said Dean Sladen, an aerospace engineer for Accu Components.

"Any engine fix that holds up the next flights, including the planned attempt to catch the ship with the launch tower's arms (after re-entry), eats into that schedule," he said.

SpaceX did not immediately respond to requests for comment.

A NASA spokesperson did not address questions for comment on the engine issue or its Artemis programme, instead pointing to a post on X from the head of the space agency, Jared Isaacman, saying Starship had "achieved an important milestone."

'The real pressure is the moon'

A longer delay would pose not only a greater setback to SpaceX's commercial ambitions to rapidly expand its Starlink broadband satellite network, but its pivotal role in NASA's Artemis moon programme.

Raptor engine and propulsion-system issues have contributed to several previous Starship setbacks, including an engine that failed to ignite as planned during Starship's 12th flight in May. The methane-fuelled engines are among the most complex and expensive components on the rocket. During some previous flights, SpaceX scrubbed plans to test-ignite the Raptor engine in space. But all of the engines successfully fired during ascent on Starship's 13th flight in July.

SpaceX is competing with Blue Origin, the rival rocket company from fellow entrepreneur Jeff Bezos, to usher in an era of lunar exploration under NASA's Artemis programme.

While SpaceX was originally contracted to provide the first crewed lunar lander for Artemis, Isaacman said in April that NASA would go with whichever lander was ready to fly first. NASA saw the added competition as healthy for progress in light of mounting delays in Starship's test flight programme.

NASA officially aims to return astronauts to the moon's surface by 2028, a target widely seen as overly ambitious, to get there ahead of China, which plans a crewed lunar landing by 2030.

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

The world faces a 'narrowing window' to restore forests essential to food security and the climate. A quiz on forests

Radhika Santhanam

QUESTION #1

This layer of the tropical rainforest receives the most sunlight. It is also home to the majority of the rainforest's plant and animal species. The layer also refers to a cloth covering suspended over a bed or an ornamental roof-like structure. Name the layer.

QUESTION #2

Taiga in Russian means 'land of little sticks'. Which hemisphere is a vast majority of the taiga biome — characterised by long, severe winters and short summers and coniferous evergreen trees — located in? Also give the widely used name for the taiga biome, which comes from a Greek word.

QUESTION #3

Underneath the forest floor, intertwined with the roots of the trees, is a network of fungus. It helps trees share nutrients, water, and

chemical warning signals. What is it called? Also, if www refers to the worldwide web, this network is a different kind of www, as dubbed by the German forester Peter Wohlleben. What does this www stand for?

QUESTION #4

These are unique ecosystems that thrive in the interface between land and sea. They account for less than 1% of global tropical forests but they are critical ecosystems as their tangled roots provide protection against storms and erosion. Examples of these ecosystems in India include the Sundarbans and Pichavaram. What are they called?

QUESTION #5

These forests cover an area larger than Alaska and span six countries. They house the critically endangered forest elephant and the largest number of great ape species. The forests are named after a country that is the 11th largest in the world and where French is the most widely spoken language. Name these forests.



Visual: Name this place, which reports 0% recorded forest area in India. JULIO (CC BY-SA)

Answers to September 22 quiz:

1. Only mammal covered in true scales – **Ans: Pangolins**
 2. Source of the greenish tinge of sloth fur – **Ans: Algae**
 3. Bird with a spiky crest; national bird of Guyana – **Ans: Hoatzin**
 4. Animal that uses leafy appendages to camouflage – **Ans: Leafy sea dragon**
 5. Musk ox's soft, fine underwool prized for light textiles – **Ans: Qiviut**
- Visual: **Lyrebird**

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For feedback and suggestions for 'Science', please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Daily page'